On the Edge of Time and Space

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36511867.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

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M/M

Fandoms:
Marvel Cinematic Universe, She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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James "Bucky" Barnes/Steve Rogers, Peggy Carter & Steve Rogers, Steve Rogers & Avengers Team, Thorki in the author's cut

Characters:
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On the Edge of Time and Space

by Aquatigermice, Call_Me_Kayyyyy (Cheeky9274)

Summary

What do you do when life keeps coming at you? When everyday brings a new punch to the face? Do you let it drag you down? When you fall do you stay down or do you get back up?

Steve has taken many hits over the course of his life. Some were easy to rise above. Others took him some time to pull himself together. But one thing remained the same. Steve would not give up on his friends, his home and his family.

Ahead of him loomed the biggest battle of his life. One that would change the future of the whole universe. The balance rests on the edge of these moments, where battles are fought, trust and faith are ripped apart and reformed, secrets come out and Steve and his fond family figure out who they are.

I present to you On the Edge of Time and Space a Marvel SheRa crossover.

Notes

Things you need to know. This story is a Captain America/She-Ra crossover. It is based on the Netflix series 2018 rebooted series. If you haven't seen it yet, I would recommend it. But you don't have to have seen it to understand this story.

If you have seen it you will recognize some of the lines from the show here and there. The last thing you need to know is that Steve is two different sizes. During the majority of the story he is pre-serum size. But he is stronger and in better

health than in the MCU. When he is Captain Rogers he is post-serum weight and height.

This story is for the Marvel Reverse Big Bang 2021 for the Multiverse Phase. The art is by Call_Me_Kayyyyy with the title of Steve-Ra and Buckitty. Which can be found here in the story. Beta by Neverever.

Also to Call_Me_Kayyyyy I soooo sorry that you had to wait as long as you did. But the first draft was not worthy of you and the art. And my Beta made sure I knew that. So I took my time and now we have this. So I hope that you most of all enjoy it. Once more I am sorry for going past the deadline.

Please enjoy.

See the end of the work for more notes

- Inspired by [Art Masterpost] Stucky She-Ra AU by Call_Me_Kayyyyy (Cheeky9274)

Chapter 1



Prelude: To My Young Ones

Peggy's vision blurred with tears as she yanked on the controls one more time. There was still no change in the course nor any response from the ship. The only thing that seemed to be working was the communication equipment. Peggy refused to cry, not when she still had work to do.

Maybe once her tasks were done and the job completed, she would let herself cry. That was if she had time. Peggy had always known that this was a possible outcome. It was why she left the Sword behind on this trip. It was also why she had King Odin put her young Wards to sleep. Peggy, Howard and Darlene had been over the plans many many times. Coming up with outcomes for all possibilities.

Which was a smart thing now with her death fast approaching. It was good to know that even with herself out of the picture, the Rebellion could go on. Hopefully if what she was doing worked, no one would be able to use the Captain ever again. And with Darlene pregnant, the Sergeant powers had been locked away for now.

But, and this she hated, if this didn't work, her Young Ones could always be awakened to take up the sword and the Captain and Sergeant's mantle. Peggy hoped that it wouldn't come to that. It was bad enough that Thanos was hunting down their people. And

with the power of the Stones now out of reach, Peggy knew that the ancient race of the SSR would go extinct soon.

That thought tugged a little on her heart. Just for a second though. Her people deserved it after all they had done. To her. To the children. To Darlene whose only crime had been finding love. In the eyes of the SSR, Darlene was not one of them anymore. Especially with a half-breed on the way. The power of the Sword would never obey her calls now.

So maybe doing this was saving Darlene and the children that she would later have.

It was best that all the ugliness of their people would end with Peggy. What was good and kind could continue on with her Young Ones, Her Wards.

With them in mind, Peggy calmly typed in the final codes. Her fingers moved fast over the keys without much thought. She had always been like that, laser focused on whatever problem laid before her. It was why she had been chosen. At least that's what her Superiors had said. Peggy knew now that it took a lot more for the Sword of Erskine to choose its wielder than stubbornness.

It mostly looked at the heart. A good heart, a kind soul and a mind for others. It was this that drove Peggy now. With a deep breath, Peggy smiled as she pressed the last button. A screen popped up over the windshield. It didn't cover the whole thing. Peggy could still see the planet growing larger. She took her eyes away from that, focusing instead on the image of herself.

"Hello, my Young Ones," she said clearly. "If you are hearing this message it means that I have failed you. And for that I am sorry. I never wanted the burden of the Sword to be on the two of you. Not because you couldn't handle it. Never because of that. If there were any two capable of the weight and responsibilities of the Sword, it's you two."

Peggy took a moment to think of what to say. Trying not to look at how the view had changed. The surface of the planet was visible through the windshield now. Growing closer and closer. She tried to keep her panic from her voice as she continued. "With that said, I am proud to tell the two of you that you have graduated from Young Ones. You are now considered adults among our people. This also means that your training with me is coming to an end. It will be up to the Sword now to see who will bear the title of Captain and who will be the Sergeant."

There was a strong trimmer that had started in her hand. It was slowly working its way up her arm. Soon her whole body would be shaking. "I want you boys to know," Peggy's voice betrayed her, breaking as she spoke. She swallowed the lump in her throat. She needed to do this. "You were the best Wards one could ever have. I am so proud of you both."

Now the tears were flowing. But Peggy could now make out the dark mass that was the ground as it reached for her. She had been wanting to rest for so long. And in a moment she could. "I don't know what will be in your future. But I do know as long as you Steven and you James look out for each other, there is nothing you cannot do. Goodbye. I'll be watching." With unsteady hands, Peggy clicked the message off.

She briefly worried about James and Steve but if Howard's plan worked, then a part of her would still be there for them. Darlene could help too if she was still alive. Shaking Peggy sat back in the pilot's seat. She had done all she could. She had lived a life. Her only regret was that her Wards, her Young Ones did not get to live theirs.

A moment later Margaret 'Peggy' Carter, the 106th Captain closed her eyes and greeted death.

Prologue: The Doctor, the Heir and the Ice Prince

Zola stared down at the chaotic operating theater below. It had been a long time since he had to oversee a double operation. Not since the twins. It was always so risky. But the reward was greater when they were bonded souls like this. Zola was very excited about the recent turn of events, though those around him couldn't tell.

No, on the outside Zola was calm and collected as he shouted out orders. If they did this right, it would be a major blow to the Rebellion. Not only would they gain two fighters but they could finally have a face for this Clutch of Hydra. One Zola knew that could lead them to victory. Something that they would need in the coming months.

Lord Thanos would finally be coming. Zola had almost felt tears come to his eyes at the news that the messages their branch had been sending were finally showing pending instead of error. This Clutch of Hydra had been separated from the main Head for so long. They weren't meant to be away for that long. It was true that they could survive as long as they could continue to turn others. But Hydra thrived with other Main Heads, Thanos and his children being around.

Zola sighed. Schmidt would have been so happy to see this moment. Rage flitted through Zola. Captain Carter may have wounded Schmidt and put their Clutch into this isolated prison but her Successor had given them everything they needed for a victory.

"Your Grace," a voice interrupted Zola's thoughts. Zola turned and smiled at the young man. The young one that had brought them this great victory. Zola looked over the young man's appearance, jet black hair, red eyes and blue skin. Loki wouldn't remain that way for much longer. Zola still had a few more touches to the potion so that Loki could have what he wanted. The transformation would be the easier of the two requests that the young Frostling demanded for the many secrets he held.

Zola was sure that once they got his new science project up and running the other request would be simple to complete.

"Speak, Loki," Zola said, turning back to the activities below. They were finishing up, all that was left was to close up the incisions. Then they would need to wait to see if they survived. Their odds were very favorable. After all, they had Erskine's power flowing through them both.

"Lord Pierce wishes to speak with you. He just sent a messenger," Loki said, his voice distracted. Zola saw that he was watching what was happening below. The boy was curious. It was what drew him to Hydra in the first place. That and the fool of a King, Odin, who even before his disappearance, thanks to Hydra, had been so focused on his real son to give the little Frostling anything more than a passing interest.

The Rebellion was often like that, so focused on its heroes, their Avengers, that they missed out on those that could be useful.

Their loss.

Loki had so much potential and a thirst to prove that he wasn't just the adopted son. And Hydra was going to use all they could and more until there was nothing left. Zola smiled at Loki, "I figured. Come with me then," Zola instructed, after one last look below he exited the room. Loki followed a moment later. "I don't understand why, Sir," Loki mumbled.

"You need to give your account to our Leader. Then we need to discuss what to do next," Zola said simply. Zola knew that he needed to make sure Loki felt like he was an important member of this team. Loki already had a proven track record of being capable of betrayal. With the right push from Hydra, Loki would go running back to the Avengers and his adopted brother with every secret he had learned. Of course Zola was already putting a fail safe into the skin spell. A little insurance for the day that Loki did try to run. In Zola's mind death was the only way to exit Hydra.

Loki didn't reply back but he followed behind Zola as they moved through the labyrinth that was the hallways. When Schmidt had built the base, he had made many small things that helped to keep their base safe from the Rebellion. The location alone had been enough so far but if the Rebellion ever made it into the base the hallways would keep them busy.

Pierce, when he took over after his father's death, built a few more passageways with the only purpose being to lead around to another equally long hallway. It would give Hydra the choice of confronting the enemy or leaving them to die.

Quite a brilliant plan. Zola hoped one day they would be able to put one or two of the Avenger's members in the hallways. He would love to study their decline.

Perhaps with Thanos arriving he would get the chance, Zola thought as he knocked on the door to Pierce's office.

"Enter," Pierce called. He was standing over a huge desk where a map of the planet was laid out. Pierce looked up doing a double take as they stepped in. "Ahhhh, Prince Loki. I am very glad you have arrived safely," Pierce said as he made his way over to them, arm outstretched. Zola watched quietly as Pierce offered Loki a seat and something to drink before asking for the details of the events that had happened.

Zola had already heard the story already. How Loki had convinced young Prince Stark of a hair-brained plan that involved charging their Stones, giving them the power to crush their enemies. Only Stark didn't realize the power came with a cost. The life of all six Stone wielders.

The only way of breaking the spell was for one of the Stones to be destroyed. Captain Rogers had been able to use the strength granted to him by the Sword to shatter the blade. It didn't exactly destroy the Stone, but it did create enough cracks in Rogers' bond with his Stone to break the spell. The backlash of power was able

to pull the planet out of the pocket dimension that Captain Carter's death had moved it to in an effort to hide the Stones.

Breaking the Sword had also blasted Sergeant Barnes right off the mountain that the fight had been taking place on. Captain Rogers had jumped right after him. And while the Avengers scrambled to form a search party and to lick their wounds, Loki had used his magic to find the pair and bring them to Hydra. The pair were both injured by the blast of power and the fall. Some of which were things that Zola could fix.

There was one flaw right now since Steve was not in his form of Captain Rogers but Zola was sure they could find a way to get the young man to transform. There was still time. They were just lucky that the powers of the Sergeant didn't come with any fancy transformation. Barnes would be the new fist of Hydra. Steven, if it didn't work out, would be a great handler.

"Thank you, Loki, for your service to the cause. Because of your actions, we were able to send a message to our great leader Thanos. He will be coming for us and the Stones," Pierce said proudly.

"We will make sure Thanos hears that his coming success was only made possible because of you," Zola added. They both watched as Loki glowed under the praise. It was kind of sad to see the kid like this. Zola had no doubt that Hydra was the bad guy. He knew what Thanos' real plan was. Some would say it was crazy. Some would probably jump teams. But for Zola and for Pierce, they didn't care.

All Zola wanted was to be able to do any type of experiments that crossed his mind. The Strategic Scientific Reserve, the people who fancied themselves as the protectors of the universe while willing to go to war with the whole galaxy to promote their brand of peace, were not willing to entertain the slightest thoughts on human experimentation. Something Zola thought was funny since the SSR knew barely anything about their mascot/greatest warrior, the Captain.

Their loss, he supposed. He wouldn't waste the opportunity that was granted to him now. Not when he had two super-soldiers to work with.

Zola smiled as Pierce sent Loki off to his new grand rooms. With nothing but the "best for a great warrior as yourself." Turning to Zola, the softness that he faked with Loki now gone, Pierce asked, "How was the surgery?" "It went well. We will know in a matter of hours if it worked or if additional procedures are needed." Zola hoped that more surgeries were needed.

"Good, keep me informed. With my Grandfather coming, I hoped to have Midgard ready for him. It might soften his punishment towards us. At the least we can have the Captain and the Sergeant under our orders," Pierce reasoned. Zola had known Thanos for a long time. Kindness was rare. But the Captain, the Sergeant and the SSR had been a pain in his side for a long time.

With them back with the rest of the universe now, they were slowly getting old reports of what had been happening while Midgard had been gone. Sadly both their communication systems were outdated and the satellites seemed to no longer exist.

They were getting their information from the closest Hydra communications hub in the next solar system over. But one piece of good news was that Thanos and his children were able to put down the SSR for good. Sure there were still minor rebellions around the galaxy. But the major threat was the Captain and the power that could be wielded by the Stones which Captain Carter had brought to this planet.

If they could keep control of the Captain. Then it was possible to do the same with the wielders of the other Stones. That might be enough to spare them the worst of Thanos' rage. Zola cursed his luck that Schmidt had chosen him as his Lieutenant. Thanos had two favorite children. Gamora was one. And Schmidt was the other.

"We can only wait and see what kind of mood he is in when he arrives," Zola pointed out. Zola left it unsaid that a scientific breakthrough, especially one with the mind chips, would be in their best interest.

Zola would be busy. Luckily he would have plenty of test subjects with all the places they would be taking control of while the Avengers were down. Time was on their side too. It would take Thanos some time for the messages to reach him and to arrive on this side of the universe. But that meant plenty of time to experiment.

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Chapter 1: Awake

The pain was still fading when Steve came back to himself. All his muscles ached in a way that meant that he had just finished a hard fight. A fight that he remarkably didn't remember having.

There was also something that was nagging him in the back of his mind that he couldn't understand. That and why he was pinned down in the dirt. There were several hands all over him holding him down. And one particularly strong set on his head. Steve gave a hard thrash to see if he could throw them off.

His strength didn't come to him as it should. Instead all he ended up doing was a slight buck of his hips. It was then that Steve noticed that he was in his normal body and not that of the Captain. There was a familiar whirring sound of gauntlets that made Steve still and listen to the conversation that was taking place above him. "I thought you said this would work, Bruce? Why is he still fighting us?" Tony's voice sounded stressed and tired. "I said that it could work depending on what Zola did. If he fused the chip to the nerve system, we may have a harder time getting him free," Bruce hissed back.

"Tony?" Steve grunted out around the weight on his chest. The conversation came to an abrupt stop as the bodies on Steve stilled. There was a shuffling of shoes as they moved around Steve's body to stand in front of him. "What did you say?" Tony asked slowly in disbelief.

"What is going on, Tony?" Steve hissed out. "Get him up," Sam said to Steve's left. Steve felt the hands on him hurriedly drag him upwards.

Steve's eyes darted around taking in everything. He was standing in a clearing. The surrounding trees and ground showed varying signs of a really bad fight. Steve wondered what on Earth he and the others could have been fighting.

Beside Tony and Bruce, there was Thor and Sam who stood off to Steve's left. Each one of them looked a little worse for wear. And all of them stared at Steve as if he was some kind of wild and strange beast that would attack at any moment.

"Steve?" Tony asked questionably as he stepped forward. "Do you know who we are?" Bruce asked. And Steve had to cock his head to the side. Something about all of this wasn't right. Steve tried thinking back to how he ended up here but he was having a hard time remembering. In fact he couldn't recall anything recent.

His mind as well as his memories were a little hazy. "Of course, I know who you are. Why are you guys acting strange? What is going on here?" Steve asked, frowning as he looked at each one of them.

Tony moved closer, taking Steve's hands in his own. His eyes were wide with sadness. "You have been in the clutches of Hydra for a few years now." Steve was going to object but then he looked at Tony.

At the others. They all looked different than Steve remembered. Older. Tony was even sporting gray hairs.

Then after another look around, Steve turned back fast to glare at Tony. "Where is Bucky?" Steve's heart drummed hard in his chest. He knew even before Tony opened his mouth. It was in the way that no one would meet his eyes.

"Sorry, Steve. Hydra had you both. We tried to free you, both of you. But it took all of us just to hold you down," Tony stated. Tony was going to keep talking but Steve cut him off with a sharp shake of his head. He yanked his hands out of Tony's soft grip as he stepped back.

"I'm sorry," Tony said, reaching out for Steve but changing his mind halfway. Steve didn't have anything to say in reply. He just stared at the ground. He already knew that there was no way that he could leave Bucky behind. He would go after Hydra. He would find out what they had done to him.

But for now. Just for a moment he would let himself feel the pain that his best friend was still in the clutches of Hydra.

Taking a deep breath Steve let out a wail of all his frustrations and pain that echoed deep into the forest.

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Chapter 2: Asset Two

Asset Two moved fast through the woods letting his strong thigh muscles and his claws to help put distance between him and the enemy.

There was something new echoing through his chest. It resonated with the pain in his arm. It kept him moving forward even without the Other. The Other that should be at his side at all times.

'You're scared,' said a voice Asset Two knew. It often talked to him, though he didn't tell his Handlers. He almost told the Other, Asset One, but for some reason he didn't. He was sure if he did, the Head Doctor would do more conditioning. But now that Asset

Two thought about it, he was probably in for far worse now with this failure.

Asset Two let out a growl. Base was not going to be happy with the results of this mission. He would just have to hope that the report that he gave would be enough to show how much Hydra had underestimated the Rebellion forces. Something that Asset One had kept voicing that they should always be prepared for.

'Steve always had a good eye for planning,' the voice stated. It made Asset Two frown. He did not know who this Steve was. That information seemed irrelevant. The voice always seemed to give Asset Two conflicting data. Like during the battle it told Asset Two not to take a killshot. Asset Two still didn't understand why he actually listened.

If he had taken the shot, Asset One would still be here with him. 'You shouldn't have left Stevie. He would have never left you,' the voice said. Asset Two shook his head, hissing out a pained "Shut Up!!" Hadn't the voice done enough already. Asset Two was alone now. He had heard Asset One screams, and knew the Rebels had killed him.

'You should have let them take you. It would be so much better than going back to Hydra,' the voice reasoned. Asset Two hated to admit it but it was true. But he also didn't want to die. So that meant going back to the Land of Nightmares.

The Forest around Asset Two slowly gave way to barren gravel. Ahead was the large volcano. Situated around it were the many buildings that Hydra had built. Asset Two's nose scrunched up at the smell of sulfur. There was a permanent haze in the air that clung to the fur of his ears and tail. Asset Two disliked the smell. He was also aware he wasn't allowed to have personal feelings like that.

Asset Two didn't have any time to think about anything more; there was a unit of guards waiting for him at the gate. Gradually he slowed his speed until he stopped in front of them. "Where is

Asset One?" a guard asked, looking behind Asset Two like the other would appear at any second. "Take me to see Pierce." Asset Two gritted out. His tone conveyed that he would not be speaking any longer on the matter with them.

The guards had a quick talk to one another before they led the way, surrounding Asset Two like he was their prisoner. 'You are Barnes,' the voice whispered back. Asset Two disregarded it. Instead he focused on the goings on of the Base. They were preparing for another attack. It was really all they ever did.

They were either attacking or getting ready to attack. "The evil forces of the Rebellion never sleep or stop planning. Neither should we," Pierce had said at a briefing with the Assets during their earlier missions. The Rebellion, especially their special unit of heroes; the Avengers were often at the same battles that the Assets were sent to. Asset Two wouldn't say it aloud but they were worthy fighters.

"Hey!" a voice called out to them. Asset Two flinched at the sound of the Head Doctor Zola. Zola was coming from the other direction. His arms were always full of papers. The deep wrinkles of his forehead were caused by all the worrying he was constantly doing, furrowing more as he took in the situation. "Where is the other Asset?"

The guards looked at one another but Asset Two said clearly, "I need to make my mission report to Pierce." Zola shifted his load before adjusting his spectacles to give Asset Two a searching glare. Asset Two knew this was a test so he stood firm under the gaze. Zola gave a slight grin before turning to the guards. "I will take him the rest of the way. I need to see Pierce anyways. Come Asset," Zola said, moving past the now dismissed guards.

Asset Two followed behind Zola as they made their way through the hallways to the door. Zola only gave a short rap on the wood before entering. Pierce sat at a huge desk. The only furniture in the room, beside the chair that Pierce was sitting in. The holographic display of the planet was lit up with different lights

that showed where Hydra was currently fighting as well as the Rebellion's strongholds.

At their entrance, Pierce looked up at them and glared. "Report," he said calmly before narrowing his eyes. "We defeated the Rebellion at the points you sent us. The last location a few Avengers showed up. We fought them through the city and into the woods. There we were ambushed by reserved forces. They were able to separate us. They aimed to capture us. They tried to attack the backs of our heads. I was able to throw off my attackers. But Asset One was not.

After weighing the options and the fact that I was outnumbered and the enemy was going to attack me again – Asset One was screaming in intense pain – I made a tactical decision and returned to Base." Asset Two lowered his head when he was done speaking.

It was quiet before Pierce spoke. "I see." Asset Two didn't dare look up as he awaited his punishment. "Longing." At the first word Asset Two's whole body locked up. The voice within screamed but by the third word it had gone quiet. After the last word Asset Two responded with "Ready to comply."

Pierce ignored him to look at Zola. "They seemed to have been attacking the chip. Is it possible for them to be able to take back control of Rogers?" Pierce asked. "If they hit the chip with the right amount of power, then yes. It means that the Avengers have Steven back," Zola replied back.

"I supposed it was a minor loss. We could never get him to trigger the Captain. And he destroyed his weapon before we captured him. He didn't even have his stone on him when he was brought to us," Pierce said the last part more to himself but Zola still nodded his head in agreement.

"Let's move on to Phase Two. The Twins should be ready, let's send them out. Back them up with Loki," Pierce ordered. "And what of Asset Barnes?" Zola asked casually. "Give him a more

permanent chip. Something that can't be so easily removed," Pierce ordered. Then he added, "Perform a wipe on him too. Erase Rogers completely from him. We will now refer to Barnes as the Asset. That way when Rogers returns to the field, Barnes here can eliminate him."

Zola gave a curt nod, calling to the Asset to follow as he left the room.

Asset Two heard all this, to him it meant nothing as he followed Zola for maintenance. But deep inside him, in the place where James Buchanan Barnes hid and survived, he clutched tight to the new information. One day he would be free again until then he would gather what he could and wait.

Stevie would come for him.

...

Chapter 3: Captain Carter

A bright orange light shone beside where Steve sat, clueing him in to her arrival. Steve had started to worry that she wouldn't show. He had been in the Captain's Vault for ten minutes already without so much of a crackle of light. Normally she was always so fast to appear before him. Almost as if she was just waiting for Steve to return to her again. Not for the first time did Steve wonder what she did when there was no one here.

There were a few long moments where neither of them spoke, further convincing Steve that she was disappointed in him. And he failed her. That he was not worthy of the title that was passed to him. Seeing the light made him let out a breath that he had been holding.

"Captain Carter," he started but he couldn't say anything more. His voice breaking on the title. The title that they both had shared. That she had upheld to the very bitter, lonely and painful

end. And that he had undone so simply. Getting himself, as well as the planet, into a mess.

"Steve," her soft voice echoed around the huge empty chamber. He didn't look up though. He couldn't face her, not yet. Steve did note that she didn't sound mad at all. It made him wonder how much Sam had told her.

Sam, though he never received training to become a super-soldier like his mother, was a warrior like those on his father's side. But because he was half SSR, the vault of Captains allowed him in, something that Steve figured was Captain Carter's doing.

The Captain's Vault was fickle like that. Was designed to obey the current Captain. Its location was also chosen by the current Captain. Steve had left it here in the woods just outside of Asgard because he couldn't bear to move it.

Steve supposed it was a good thing he didn't move it since Hydra had taken over so many places now. The only real question was how many details had Sam given. Like Bucky, Sam was a close friend and had the habit of covering for Steve. But even if Sam didn't tell her everything, she seemed to be able to feel what was happening. Margaret Carter was the smartest and most bravest person Steve had ever known. Things rarely slipped past her.

The light grew brighter as it moved to stand in front of him. Steve kept his eyes firmly on her black heeled boots. Bucky and he used to be in awe at how Miss Carter moved in her everyday wear. How quick and sure footed she was while she sparred with them both or showed them combat moves in this very room.

Steve's heart gave a shudder at the thought of Bucky's name. Another person that had to suffer because he wasn't strong enough. "Steven," Captain Carter said again as she knelt down before him. When he turned his head to look away, she reached out a hand and turned him back to her. The pressure was soft but cool on his skin. The low hum and soft popping reminding Steve that while her consciousness was saved, her body was long gone.

"I am sorry," he stuttered out as he finally looked at her. She was a never-aging beauty with a sharp mind that never dulled. This mirror perfect image of his Captain that was as real as she was fake.

She gave him a mischievous smile as she asked, "And why is that Steven?" Steve swallowed before he tried to speak again. "That I wasn't like you. That I couldn't get the job done." His bitter words cut deep as he spoke. "For being so useless without the Sword." He wanted to say more but Miss Carter held a finger to his lip stopping him from confessing everything and more.

"Steven," she began as she sat down. "I know that it is hard to believe but being Captain isn't just the Sword or the Stone. It's your soul magnified." Carter placed her hand onto his chest tapping her fingers where his heart laid. "It's why there isn't just one set way of being the Captain. It is why everyone who takes up the mantle is different. And while without the Stone, you don't have all the strength or ultimate body that the Captain's form provides, you still are the Captain because you are still you."

He stared at the hand before countering. "But you hid the planet from Hydra to save everyone. I brought it back out into the open and right back into the path of Hydra. I failed," Steve admitted. Carter shook her head. "I hid us, Steven, so we could fight another day. You brought us out of hiding because it was the only way to stop the spell young Stark had made," she replied back. "But it killed Queen Frigga. It got Bucky and me captured. He killed King Howard and Queen Maria and I helped destroy the land of Technology while under Hydra's control. Bucky is still stuck there and who knows what Hydra is going to do to him?!" He yelled back at her.

Once he had finished, he immediately wanted to take back those words or at least how he said them. Carter was his trainer, his family and she didn't deserve to be yelled at like that. "Oh Steven," she said with a laugh. "There is still so much for you to learn, so much more for you to know, my Young One."

She continued, "No one made Queen Frigga do anything. She gave her life just like I did because we both knew that you and the Avengers were the future, the key to winning. In doing so, you were able to discover that King Odin was still alive. And while the pair of you did almost destroy the land of Technology, there are witness accounts that he spared the young prince and you left his Stone. Something that would have tipped the balance in the favor of Hydra.

“This is a war, Steven. A long one that has cost us many lives. I hoped that you won't lose anymore but sitting here wallowing in your defeats won't get you any more wins. James is still alive. Which means we can get him back. So my question to you is, are you going to continue to sit there doing nothing or are you going to do something about it?" She asked as she stood. She brushed herself off before reaching down for him.

Steve stared at her, his Captain, she always seemed to know what he needed to hear. She was right, there was still time to save Bucky. They could save this planet.

"Thank you, Captain Carter," he said, taking her hand. She pulled him to his feet with ease. "Call me, Peggy. You're the Captain now." Pride rang in her voice.

"If you insist." Steve glowed at the thought of her being proud of him. "I do. So how do you want to proceed, Captain Rogers?" Peggy asked.

Steve had never thought he would get the title of Captain. He was sure the Sword would choose Bucky. That the leaders of the SSR chose him as a joke for their own entertainment. But they were dead and the power was his now. Well, if he could control it. Without the Sword to help focus, the power came and went. When he could pull it forward, the power was unruly. It meant that he couldn't really be on the battlefield to fight, not with his body stuck in his normal form. Though he could help out in other ways. The power of the Captain while affecting his body had nothing to do with his already brilliant brain.

For now he could direct the others. The good thing about the Avengers was that Steve wasn't the only one leading it. Sure Thor was the muscle, Tony was the brain and engineer and Steve was the one to be right in the middle of it all to direct them. He would have to find a way around that. Pull back from the field and coach from a distance. But he would need a way to use the Captain's powers if/when they would go up against Hydra and get Bucky back. The power of the Captain was too great of a weapon to keep locked away.

If anyone could figure it out it would be him. Plus he had help. He still had people he could trust to fight by his side.

"I think it is time the Avengers assembled," Steve said thoughtfully. Peggy nodded. "That would be a wise course of action," she agreed.

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Chapter 4: The Ghost With the Metal Arm

The workshop had grown quiet after Thor had finished speaking. His words were still hanging in the air. Chilling and cold like the moments before snow falls.

Steve had to sit down, his knees were shaking so hard they clacked against one another. Tony walked over to the minibar to pour himself a drink.

If the liquid would do Steve any good, he would drink too. At times it was a blessing that he couldn't get drunk. Kept him focused on what lay ahead.

This was not one of those moments.

Steve sighed trying to think before he spoke. "Ok, let's go over it one more time," he spoke decisively. He wanted to make sure that

Thor wasn't twisting up his words once more. Thor did that when he got excited.

"You, Nat and Clint met the enemy in the lands of Rush," Steve said. He could hear Sam writing down what was being said. "Yes. We went as was planned to take back Natasha's Homeland," Thor replied back. He had a few cuts and his arm was in a sling but he was in better shape than Nat and Clint.

Both of them were still in the medical wing. The Healers said that Clint had to be put under heavy medications because of his wounds. Nat on the other hand was drained. She had to use her power during the battle to help them escape.

Power that she didn't have. It was the whole point of them going to the lands of Rush. While each of them had Stones with powers. Those Stones needed to be recharged in the capital cities of their respective homelands. Howard had once explained that these places were once towns started by Peggy and that she built charging stations into each one. This meant that Thor, whose Homeland was the base of operations for the Rebellion and the Avengers, was always charged and ready. Bruce and Steve's Stones (when Steve had one) could charge by being around the others.

This was a good thing since Bruce's Homeland of Longmans had been turned into a desert when Peggy's ship crashed back down into the planet. Steve on the other hand didn't have a Homeland anymore. He and Bucky were selected at a young age to train under Peggy. Steve doesn't remember any of those tests that the Elders did to pick him. Steve's earliest memories were of a blond, feisty looking woman waving to him as Steve was being taken aboard the ship that brought him to this planet.

The other one was of a pair of pale blue gray eyes that looked fondly at Steve from the other tube that they were placed in for their journey. Steve had never seen a Nekomimi before. He spent the whole journey trying to catch glimpses of Bucky's ears and tail. Steve was now an expert at telling Bucky's mood by how he

moved his ears and tail. Something that would be helpful right now if they had footage of the fight. Steve mentally added talking to Tony about some type of surveillance or recording tech. They would need it for future battles and for scouting Hydra's bases before battle. Since with the deactivation of Steve's chip he lost all his memories of his time with Hydra.

It would help with the plan. The Avengers had hoped that once they regained control of Rush that Tony could do like he did in Downingtown after Steve and Bucky had destroyed the capital. Which was to remove the charging base and reroute the power lines of the lands to Asgard.

After that step was completed, the next step was to get Natasha all powered up again before they went for Clint's Homeland. Waverly had been a beautiful place once upon a time. Like Longmans, it had suffered a great blow in the past due to outside interference.

While Longmans had been an accident, Waverly had been caused by the royal family handing over their Stone and lands to Hydra in a move that they hoped would save the lives of their people. Instead they all became the first in Hydra's new army on Midgard.

At some point right before Steve and Bucky had been awakened, Hydra decided to kill off the royal family. Barney, Clint's older brother, was able to help his brother escape. With Clint gone, the Stone power's decreased, meaning Zola's ability to experiment also went down. Since then Zola must've had a breakthrough since he was able to take control of Steve and Bucky.

They hoped that by getting into Waverly, they could either mount a force big enough to take the land back. Or get Clint to the Stone and use their combined power to defeat Hydra and save the planet. The second option they were a little hesitant to execute since Steve's connection to his Stone had been through the Sword. Peggy was doing what she could with training but she didn't know it all. And with Darlene long dead, Peggy was all Steve had.

The plan was solid. And now with Steve back, it should have worked.

Only Loki, the youngest son of the ruler of the neutral northern wastelands, who was traded to Asgard for monthly shipments of supplies, also knew of that plan. And was now on Hydra's side. Loki showed up at most of the battles recently. He and a pair of twins that had magical abilities. The Avengers had gone up against the trio enough times now over the past few months to start to figure out a game plan to counter them.

Until now.

"We paired off like you advised us to do Steven," Thor said. His voice hinted at the deep sadness within. Thor had a weak spot for Loki. It hurt him that not only had Loki left to join the side of evil but had a hand in Queen Frigga's death. It was only with the help of the other Avengers that Thor was able to keep moving forward. Even if Loki seemed to make it a personal mission to go after Thor and tear him back apart with words and stabs of one of his mini daggers.

"They were different this time. The Twins were stronger. Faster. And Loki," Thor paused for a moment, a shiver going through his mighty form. "His appearance had been altered. He was pale white and his heritage lines were gone. When I asked what happened, he said that Hydra had remade him into something new and better. And that he wasn't the only one that Hydra had helped." Thor shut his eyes for a moment, frowning as he explained the next part.

"He was on us before we realized what was happening. He moved like a ghost. Fast and deadly. Covered from head to toe in a black combat outfit and goggles. Had cat ears and a tail that he kept pinned close to his body. The worst part was the arm. His left arm was gone. Replaced with one of metal. It took out Clint in two punches. I tried to go help Clint and Natasha but Loki kept me away until Natasha used up her power. I was able to grab them both before making a run for it. He kept up. The only reason we

escaped was because Loki called him back," Thor finished, eyes firmly fixed on a random floor tile.

"And for the record, what was the name that Loki used?" Steve asked even though he didn't want to think about it. To believe it.

"Loki called him Bucky."



Chapter 5: Contact

Steve rolled on to his back in his sleeping bag. He wasn't quite awake yet. Just coming out of a deep sleep, though he was unsure why. He always slept better nowadays on the floor. Beds were just too soft. Steve wasn't sure if it was something that Hydra had done or the misplaced power that was racing through him.

Whatever it was, Steve was much more antsy than he had been in the past. Exercise would help a lot with that. Not much since his body wasn't that strong yet. While he couldn't get his body to transform into Captain Rogers, the 6 foot 2 golden hair 260 pounds of muscle, the power blast did heal all his old ailments. Steve missed the other body but he was used to this one.

Which was helpful in a way. Steve was now forced to look at problems a different way. It had been "I could use the Captain to punch my way out of any situation." And if he did get jammed up, then Bucky could gun them down an escape path. Now Steve had to think more. Not that this was a bad thing since it helped him understand his fellow teammates more. His connection to Clint had grown since Clint's only power was being able to shoot arrows with a deadly accuracy.

That and be a damn good spy.

Both of which he was teaching to Steve. Clint would have been here now but he was still recovering from the Winter Soldier first appearance and attack. Steve refused to call him Bucky. He couldn't think of his friend, brother, his well... his everything like that. No, this was just a creation that Hydra had made. They would get Bucky back no matter what. Though everyone warned Steve that they weren't sure what Bucky would be like mentally when he came home.

Steve figured they would deal with that part later. Anything had to be better than what Hydra was using him for now. Plus Steve and the others would be there for Bucky to deal with the emotional fallout. His friends were already helping Steve heal.

The fact that Tony was here right now was lifting Steve's soul. Tony had told Steve sometime after his return, "It wasn't you, Steve. I know that now. I won't lie that there were times when I did blame you for it all but our friends, our team was there for me and are still there for me. I may have lost my blood family but I still have this family. The one that was founded by you. While you were gone, we got stronger. I believe the reason was so that we could be here for you now. So whatever you need, I am here for it. Even if that includes going after your brainwashed robo boyfriend/friend/pet whatever title you call him by."

That confession meant so much to Steve than he could ever say. Steve hoped that he could repay Tony in the future for such faith.

A loud snore had Steve looking over to where Thor was sprawled out on top of his sleeping bag. Even though Thor was still injured, he had come along. "I must see if I can persuade Loki to return. He is my brother." The team didn't argue. They all had their own ideas as to if Loki would ever come back and if he should be forgiven. They also had their theory as to what exactly was the nature of Loki and Thor's relationship. To Steve it was eerily close to what he and Bucky had. That and the look that Thor had in his

eyes every time he talked of Loki which was very familiar to Steve because it was the same way Steve had felt about Bucky.

Looking to his left, Steve stared at where Sam was sitting in a tree above them keeping watch. It was just the four of them. They had left Asgard in the hands of King Odin and a few other non-avengers and the Asgardian army who were all capable of fighting Hydra.

Steve and the others were on their way to an outskirt town. One of Tony's projects had been to get a satellite into space (when Peggy moved the planet; all the satellites were destroyed in the shift.) Getting one out there would mean global communication. Something the Avengers were in need of.

The satellite hadn't even been up in the air for more than a few hours before the system started to crash. The screens were all saying multiple errors as well as a partial message about an almost crash.

When they asked Tony what he thought, Tony had said, "Are you asking me about my theories? Ok, well, let's get weird. If my calculations are right – and they normally are – not only have we been pulled into a pocket dimension, but also our time lines are a little messed up. Meaning for us, we have only been gone for seventy years. But out here it was more than that. My guess is that it's been at least a hundred years. Probably more. A good amount of time has passed and our little planet has been forgotten. So this ship was probably on its way to wherever and didn't expect a planet to suddenly be here."

Steve ran it by Peggy who said that the theory had sounded strong. She couldn't prove any of it since all frequencies of the SSR were not replying back to her. Which also worried Steve.

The only good news was that Tony figured out what the error was from. One of the communication towers was down. "We just need to get there and make the repairs and it should be good after that." Tony had said. Steve hoped that by getting to the tower

hopefully before Hydra did, that they would be able to get some real information on what was going on after the repairs were done.

Letting out a breath, Steve rolled to the side. Dawn was still a few hours away. And when it was time to get up, they would have a lot of walking ahead of them. So it was best to get what sleep that Steve could while he had the chance. Steve let his eyes drift shut only to jerk them back open.

Steve swore he saw a flash of metal.

Straining his ears, Steve listened beyond the noise of the camp. There was the hiss of the fire, a hoot of a far off owl and then Steve heard it. The sound of a twig being snapped.

He would have ignored it, passing it off as sounds of the fire if Steve didn't know that the fire was nothing but coals. Steve closed his eyes listening as another snap rang through the air. Whoever it was was moving around the camp. And they were headed for Tony!!

Steve was up then. Scrabbling out of his sleeping bag. He could hear Sam calling his name but Steve didn't have time to reply because the Winter Soldier was stepping out of the shadows right beside Tony's bag, knife in hand.

Praying to his ancestors, to the past Captains, Steve hoped that they would give him the strength to save Tony. Steve held out his hand as the Winter Soldier raised his knife.

In one blink it was empty. Next there was a glow casting everything in a tint of green. Then a loud clunk as the Soldier's blade was held at bay by a glowing sword. A sword that was an exact replica of the Sword of Erskine. Only it was stronger in a way. Steve felt more connected to this phantom blade than he had ever been to the cold metal and steel.

Steve took just a moment to feel the joy that was singing through his body at seeing the Sword again and the slight disappointment

that his body hadn't changed too. That he was still small. Then Steve straightened his stance and pushed upwards to try and drive the Soldier away from a now awake and too stunned to move Tony. "Buck!" He hissed out. But the Soldier wasn't looking at him. He seemed frozen, staring behind Steve. Steve blinked, noticing that when he opened his eyes the pale green tint was gone. He could hear Sam and Thor moving.

The Soldier must have heard them too. Bucky's ears lifted just for a second before flattening back against his head. The Soldier took one more look at Steve, then at the sword with icy cold eyes before he turned, running into the woods.

Steve didn't even think. "Bucky!!" He called, running after him. Steve couldn't lose him again. Not when he was so close. The vines and tree roots fought his every move but Steve used his newly summoned blade to cut his way through.

The woods gave way to a small clearing. Steve was just entering it when Bucky was almost to the edge. Without much thought, Steve felt the sword shift in his hands. A moment later it was a circular shield. Doing a quick calculation Steve spun in the air, sending the shield flying.

He aimed it so that it would hit Bucky in the back of the head. It should have been enough force to knock Bucky out. Maybe even recalibrate him. Instead, Bucky stopped running, reaching out and grabbing the shield in midair with his metal arm.

Steve stared impressively at the sight. Then he had to scramble as the shield was being thrown back at him with such a force that it made Steve slide in the dirt. When he looked up Bucky was gone.

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It had been a long depressing hike to the small town closest to the crash site. One that was surprisingly lacking any more Winter Soldier sightings, as well as Loki.

The good news was that damage to the tower was not all structural. It was mostly a few frayed wires. With Tony directing them, Steve, Thor and Sam were able to redirect the remaining wiring. A task that took a little over a week to do but when it was done, they were back online with the rest of the universe.

The bad news was that Tony intercepted a message to Hydra.

Thanos, the leader of all of Hydra, was on his way with his children and all of his army.

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Chapter 6: Icy Promises

Loki took a deep breath. He wouldn't lie, what he had just seen and heard, it was not what he had figured would have happened when he defected to Hydra.

It was something right out of a nightmare.

He watched as the Techs just walked away leaving James in the chair like he wasn't a person anymore. Just an object.

Loki took a shaky step forward. "James?" he asked. The man didn't acknowledge Loki at all, just stared forward, chest moving with the heavy breaths he struggled to take. "Bucky?" Loki said cautiously, waiting for his ears to flick forward. But just like when Steve had said it, Bucky said nothing. Which was just as creepy as it had been when Loki had watched from the trees, only now this close, Loki could really see there was no response at all.

In fact it was worse, at least when Steve had said it, Bucky had responded. Now he was like a blank slate. Fear prickled at Loki's spine as he moved forward. Grabbing a towel, Loki didn't speak as he wiped away the sweat from Bucky's forehead.

When Loki was done he tried again. "Bucky? Say something," Loki begged, then he cringed, he was sounding like Thor. His brother was still pleading for Loki to come home. Loki pushed it away. There was no going back for him and there was no time to get emotional.

"Ready to comply." The soft voice shook Loki out of his thoughts. Bucky wasn't even looking at him. Still staring in the same direction he had been since Loki entered the room. Loki frowned. It didn't sound like Bucky at all. The man was normally so happy. Flirty. This was…. this wasn't him at all. Loki opened his mouth to demand him to stop playing when he heard the door open behind him.

Loki turned ready to tell whoever it was that they needed to leave. Bringing Steven and James to Hydra, as well as giving information on the Rebellion, had brought Loki a lot of authority. Or at least it had. With Steve back home, the Rebellion were now aware of a lot of the flaws in their system that Loki had been using. It was only because Loki knew how they were, having grown up with most of them that he was able to predict a lot of their moves.

Seeing who had walked in the door, Loki bit back his words. Zola stood in the doorway with a look that Loki always saw on the good Doctor's face when he was figuring out how he could tear apart something. It was a look that the Doctor was having more and more on his face when he stared at Loki. It reminded Loki that his position was always on the edge.

"Sir," Loki said with a bow of his head. Zola nodded his head, staring a moment more before going back to his ever-present clipboard. Loki started to move. He didn't want to be around the Doctor more than he had to but he stopped by the door. Loki had seen the other soldiers that they turned with the mind chips. It didn't bother anyone since those people were still, well, people.

Even when they had both Steven and James, the pair still talked and responded to things around them. If Loki had to say, it was

like the past had been wiped from them and they were given new memories.They were still themselves, only they thought that Hydra was their home. That they had been here all their lives and that the Avengers were evil and were planning to over take this world. Then the universe.

Now it was like Zola had scooped everything that he deemed unnecessary out of James and left something that only wanted to fight and obey orders.

"Is there something you wanted?" Zola asked, irritation clear in his voice. "I just was wondering if he is okay?" Loki spoke carefully. Zola looked up from his clipboard where he was scribbling. He looked first to Loki then to James. "Him?" Zola asked, pointing his pen to where James still sat unmovingly. At Loki's nod, Zola smiled before saying. "He is better than fine. He is perfect now. His only will now is the Cause. Nothing will stop him now. Or at least when the process is done."

Zola frowned before looking back down to his clipboard. "Still have a few things to work out. Personality and will is a complicated thing. It will take some time to free the Asset of such things. But don't you worry he will be ready for your next mission."

Loki felt his heart rate increase at what this could mean. "You are planning on doing that to every one of the soldiers?" Loki asked breathlessly. Zola gave a laugh. "You think too small, Loki. But not to worry. Pierce says you're much too useful as you are."

The ‘for now’ was left unsaid. Loki was unsure of what he needed to do next. He was a survivor. And right now this wasn't surviving. It was a death sentence with a date in the near future. "I try to be," Loki said, moving to the door.

He almost had the door shut when Zola's voice rang out. "Just a reminder that we harnessed a portion of power from the Stone to change your appearance. Nothing big, nowhere like what we used on the Assets. But.. using the power like we did means it is still connected to you. Meaning that no matter where you go, we can

find you. Just thought you should know. Oh and we received word that Lord Thanos is on his way."

"Understood." Loki left the lab and made a run to his room.

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Chapter 7: Choices That Are Your Own

Steve had come to a decision while helping to fix the tower.

He had a lot of time to think. Often he was the only one who could fit in some of the places that needed fixing. Tony would often put him in a wall, only to tell Steve to hold his position most of the time because Steve needed to hold a wire still or feed it through in another direction.

And then there were the times when Hydra attacked. With them making repairs, Tony had to disable the shields meaning that they were vulnerable to attacks. Loki led an attack on them every day. And never at the same time to keep them on the edge. He also changed up who was attacking. Twins and Loki, Loki and Hydra soldiers. Winter Soldier and Loki. The possibilities kept changing. Which Steve felt was a wise decision.

Because really Steve and his friends had the advantage here. The tower was at the center of town, raised up so that it would loom over the other buildings. Giving Steve a 360-degree view of the battles that would take place below. From here Steve could easily move his friends into key positions to win the battles. They even caught a few of the enemy to question later.

And while they did win the battles here, Steve was thinking long term.

They didn't have a lot of heavy hitters. Without the Captain they had a gap. It was only while watching Tony fight that an idea came to Steve.

On their way back to Asgard Steve approached Sam.
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Steve was getting tired. Meaning he would have to come up with a different strategy soon. A battle wouldn't stop just because he was tired or ran out of power. It was a lesson that Peggy had done a few times. Send wave after wave of training drones to attack them.

Those lessons were never about winning. It took Steve awhile to understand that it was about surviving.

Hydra was now fighting like that. Sending in waves of soldiers and right when the Rebellion forces were on their last leg, that was when Hydra would send in the Winter Soldier or Loki. So far the Rebellion was still winning but Steve wasn't sure for how long.

Which was what Steve was trying to do here. Doing training so that they could be better.

"On your left," Sam grunted out as he slammed his sword downwards. It was a warning but not a normal one. It was Sam and Steve's way of telling one another that the other wasn't paying enough attention. To focus. Steve rolled quickly to the side hearing the sword make contact with the ground instead.

From there he shifted to the balls of his feet widening his stance before raising his shield. Sam's sword made contact a second later. Sam grinned in approval. "Not bad old man," Sam huffed as he shifted his weapon into a pair of handguns. Steve frowned a little tapping into the power of the Captain.

It wasn't enough power to trigger his other form. He slid that power over his skin, feeling as it reformed into a protective barrier. An armor of light. An idea he had gotten from Tony. The last plate clicked into place just as Sam started to fire. Here was where Steve really had to concentrate.

This armor was strong but it wasn't impenetrable. It meant that Steve had to keep replacing the spots that were hit. Steve knew

from past practices that he could, depending on where he was hit, let that spot be. Unfortunately Sam had caught on to this. Shooting Steve multiple times in a spot, changing the spot when Steve would move the shield.

Steve had to wonder why Sam was going with this approach. Sure replacing the damaged plates used power but very little compared to what he had. There had to be something else that Sam was planning.

As Steve counted down the bullets, he prepared to shift his shield. At the last two shots Steve pivoted ducking low under the shield. Steve moved upwards coming into a run giving Sam no time to shift his own weapon before Steve slammed the shield onto Sam's wrists.

Sam's guns clattered to the ground as Steve shifted the shield into his sword. Steve let the blade sit on Sam's neck. "Seems to me being an old man didn't stop me from winning this battle." Steve stated calmly. Sam gave Steve a smile. "Speed seems ok. But how's your hearing?" Sam asked offhandedly.

Just as Steve was going to ask what Sam meant by that, there was the whine of Tony's gauntlets off to Steve's left. Steve barely had enough time to brace before the hit came, sending him flying a few feet away.

"Did I mention that this practice I decided to step it up a notch?" Sam said coolly as Steve stood up on shaky legs. He took in the sight of both Tony and Thor standing next to Sam. Well that was unexpected Steve thought to himself.

"No problem." Steve said, taking his fight stance, sword at the ready. "I can do this all day," Steve said to the three of them. "Was hoping you would say that." Tony said, stepping forward his gauntlets warming up. Steve gave a smile of his own.

Three against one were high odds. But Steve knew all of their attack formations and weaknesses. Tony and Thor hadn't gotten

to train with him when he was small like this. Giving Steve the advantage. It would all be a matter of just taking them out one by one.

Steve looked from one to the other before picking his first target. He would take out Sam first. Than Thor since he was the strongest. Tony, he would just have to keep distracted until the end.

If anything this would be a good lesson for them all. A way for them to get better. Sending a little more power to his skin, Steve stepped forward. He would try not to beat them up too hard, Steve thought with a chuckle.

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Dawn was Steve's favorite hour.

It meant a new day. New possibilities.

And information from others.

Peggy had told Steve that while the SSR channels were still intact. There were also messages still on the servers. Steve had decided to take it upon himself to review them.

Some of them were nice. Warriors/Super-Soldiers on the fronts sending messages to loved ones at home. There were a few from Sarah Rogers to himself. It took him far too long to realize that this voice belonged to his mother. There was more to Bucky. From his Pa, Ma and his sisters. Steve made sure to transfer those to the Asgardian hard drive. He had a feeling that Bucky would need these to recover.

The majority of the messages were not pleasant. Steve was finding that the SSR had a lot of dealings that was not what he was expecting of a group that was opposing Hydra. Night after night, Steve would make his way down to the radio room. He would send out a message on what Peggy had told him was the distress channel. His message was simple. Midgard was back and

would be fighting against Thanos. Then Steve would put on the headset and make his way through the messages of the dead to patch together the final years of the SSR. In the morning he would join his team and family to plan their next move and carry on with their plan to take back their planet.

His friends all at one point or another asked if he wanted company but Steve politely declined. These were his people. And being one of the last survivors, Steve felt it was up to him to do this task.

So far Steve had a pretty good time line of the events leading up to the end of the SSR. It started with Captain Carter removing their planet. The messages were sent to their coordinates from their leader Colonel Phillips asking Captain Carter to report. Then there was some chatter about a coup before someone named Brandt from the council took over as Colonel and leader.

From there things got bad. The SSR withdrew most of its forces to focus on seeing if they could turn any of their Super-Soldiers into the Captain. Steve had listened to so many calls for help from planets in need and calls for more soldiers to report to the home planet last night that Steve had to walk away from the last three. Spending his early hours with a punching bag.

Something that Steve had a feeling he would be doing again tonight.

After centering himself, Steve listened to the first message. It was a decree to all SSR citizens to send their children to the home planet. Those that didn't would face death.

The second message was dated a month after. It was a call for help. The home planet had been attacked.

The last was of a child's voice, a surviving member of the SSR. The message was simple: The SSR was gone. S.H.I.E.L.D., run by Nicholas J Fury, was the new Resistance. Followed by a radio frequency for contact.

After talking with his fellow leaders, Steve sent out his message as always. Only this time he sent it to the S.H.I.E.L.D. line.

The reply came at dawn. "Welcome back Cap."

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Chapter 8 :The Time is Ripe to Attack

They were finally ready to attack Hydra's Headquarters. And Steve felt on edge.

This wasn't a choice that the Avengers made lightly. For one thing they were running out of time. Thanos was coming. And they needed to make sure that he didn't have any advantages. Which was why they had the plan.

The plan consisted of a handful of mini attacks. (Something that Steve had come up with.) And would end with a flooding of troops made up from the different cities of the planet, coming together to invade the Base.

So far the Avengers had all been able to enter the Base without being detected. Tony had designed some drones to help scout ahead. Sam and Tony had split off heading to the control room. Having eyes on everyone was a critical part of the mission.

Clint, Natasha and Bruce had gone down a different path. Their job was to retrieve the Stone. One of the soldiers that they had captured had mentioned that the Stone of Waverly was aiding Doctor Zola in keeping control of a majority of the soldiers here, including Bucky. Though no one could say for sure if Loki was under such control or not.

Which was why each team was taking a heavy hitter as a precaution. The information they gather told them that Loki liked to roam the Base freely. Most likely looking for secrets. Loki was

always nosey like that. Pierce would likely be in his offices, while Zola should be in the labs.

Steve had to calm himself as he made his way down the paths. He and Thor were here for Zola. They hoped by capturing him they could find a way to free Bucky and the other chipped soldiers.

The only problem was that Bucky was also said to be kept in the labs. Steve wasn't sure that if they stumbled across Zola that he wouldn't try to kill the doctor on sight. That was why Thor was with him. Even without being able to take the form of the Captain, Steve was fast and stealthy. Added with his weapon that could change form and he was a critical piece in a mission like this.

Plus Thor never got the hang of Tony's technology.

In no time, they were down to the main lab where the Stark tablet had registered a warm body.

So far the smaller labs had contained experiments in various stages of development. As well as a few discarded metal arms and some kind of chair. Steve didn't want to think about the tanks that had been lined up against the walls, each holding what looked to have been humans. Or at least something that was human at one point in time.

The more Steve saw, the more fearful he was that there wouldn't be anything left of Bucky to save. It was also making him angry. Peggy had said "Anger is a fuel. Make it yours and use it."

Thor took point as they positioned themselves around the door. Thor readied his hammer and Steve shifted his glowing shield into a sword. They weren't sure what lay beyond this door but they would try to be ready.

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Steve could feel one of his eyes swelling up from the last hard blow the metal arm had dealt him. While Steve was still using his magic on his skin, there was something about the metal of the

arm that was causing damage. Steve needed to buy himself some time to think but the Winter Soldier just kept attacking.

There was some hope that the others could help him, since Steve had lost track of them with his focus on Bucky. He and Thor had been right about the lab being where Bucky was. Only the warm body they had picked up was Loki.

Loki was able to fight them off until Zola came with reinforcements. Then Doctor Zola went to the huge tank and put in some codes. Bucky! No, it wasn't Bucky. The Winter Soldier stepped out and had been after Steve ever since Zola commanded him.

The Winter Soldier had been an unstoppable force so far. It didn't matter who was between him and Steve, whether it was enemy or friendly, the Winter Soldier took them all on. Steve would be impressed if it weren't for how beat up he was.

His bruises had bruises at this point.

As for what was going on, Steve wasn't very sure. He had seen Thor and Loki fighting it out. He had heard Tony yelling but had no clue what he had said. Bruce had gone green at some point and thrown the Soldier through a few walls.

At that time Steve had been able to see that the fight had driven him and Bucky down several hallways and into the Stone Room. Steve had been able to see both Clint and Natasha fighting someone that eerily looked like Clint. The man was more metal than anything else and his eyes were all black. Steve had only taken one step towards the pair then the Soldier was back.

Steve had to curse himself for not taking the opportunity to call his weapon to him instead. He had lost it in one of the hallways. The Soldier had done one of the moves that Peggy had taught them for disarming opponents. It furthered Steve's notion that Bucky was still in there somewhere.

The world was finally starting to stop spinning when Steve realized that the Soldier had stopped hitting him. For a second he thought that was because Bucky had finally surfaced. Steve soon realized that wasn't what was happening.

Pierce, surrounded by a heavy layer of Hydra soldiers, was yelling at the Soldier as Stark was slowly making his way closer. Steve couldn't hear what Pierce had said but he did hear the "Mission Accepted" that the Soldier replied back with. The Soldier then rose and moved towards Tony.

Steve's muddled brain knew that he needed to get to Bucky. Because if he killed Tony, their friend, there would be no coming back from that. Stumbling to his feet, Steve called for his weapon. Only having to wait a moment for it to materialize into his hand.

Quickly Steve changed its shape into that of a long staff similar to the ones that they used to use in training. It could deal out pain but it wouldn't kill unless enough force was used. Steve knew this type of weapon better than any other besides the shield.

"Bucky!" Steve called but the Soldier didn't even pause. "Bucky, this isn't you. Fight it!!" Steve called out again. Still the Soldier marched on, punching out a few soldiers as he went. Taking a deep breath, Steve channeled some of his power of the Captain, of his Stone. It flowed into him roughly without the Sword.

Taking a deep breath, Steve focused, grabbing the power within and bending it. A moment later he found himself standing in front of the Soldier. Surprising both of them. It was enough time to use the staff to pin the Soldier to the ground.

It only took a second to slip the small device out of his pocket. Slapping it onto the back of Bucky's neck. Steve stepped back as it started to hum. This was what Tony had said was a "If all else fails" option. And since Steve had gotten in some hits to the back of Bucky's neck and those hadn't worked, this looked like the best option. Even if Tony had added, "Not sure if it will just fry Zola's

mind tech or fry the brain a little too. Either way he will be free, I guess."

The humming turned into popping which was followed by Bucky's screams. Steve watched as it brought Bucky to his hands and knees. The buzzing only lasted a minute or two before it came to a stop. Leaving Bucky to fall face down on the ground.

Steve looked around not sure what to expect. Tony was still fighting Pierce. Sam was now beside Tony making quick work of the soldiers. Bruce was gathering up all the fallen soldiers and putting restraints on them. There were no more soldiers entering the room giving off the feeling that this battle was almost over. It also seemed that the fight Clint and Nat were in was also over. Steve could make out Clint's back slowly making his way over to his Stone. It seemed the plan was finally starting to work.

Looking back to Bucky, Steve slowly stepped forward. "Buck?" He questioned. There was no reply. Steve could see that Bucky was still breathing so he was feeling optimistic even if the rest of Bucky's body was still, including his tail. "Bucky, it's me, Steve. We came to get you. It's time to go home," Steve said cautiously, kneeling down beside Bucky.

Steve heard the whirl of the metal arm before he saw the flash of metal. Then he was lifted off the ground, struggling for breath as Bucky squeezed the arm. "I am home," Bucky gritted out.

The words were cold but it was the tears that were streaming down Bucky's face that let Steve know that he had been right. Bucky's eyes, while still cool gray, were filled with turmoil. "You're not home, Buck. Your home has your friends," Steve gasped out. He knew that he should probably save his breath and think of some kind of attack. But the staff felt so heavy in his hands.

Steve knew he couldn't lift it, let alone swing it. And while it hurt his throat to talk, this was working. The grip was loosening just a little as if the Soldier wanted to hear more. "Friends?" The Soldier

asked. "Yes," Steve said so full of hope that this would get his friend back. "Friends. Like me."

The second it was out of his mouth Steve knew it was the wrong thing to say. Bucky's eyes shimmered with a yellow haze before the metal hand tightened around Steve's throat. "You are my mission," the cold voice gritted out.

Steve tried to stay calm as he struggled to breathe. He needed to think.

He needed to get free.

This was not how it should end for him.

For them.

He wasn't done living yet Steve thought as his vision started to blur.

There was still so much he needed to do. To say.

'He wasn't done,' a voice within him said. It was small but strong. Warm inside his cold body.

'We are not done yet,' the voice rang in Steve's ears. A flood of power that strengthened his limbs coursed through him. He felt the metal arm drop from his throat as the light spilled out of him.

When it cleared, Steve looked down at himself and let out a gasp. "Oh," Steve said because he had changed. He was the Captain again.



"You!!" Steve heard Bucky growl out, a knife arcing towards him. Something within him clicked. There was a blast of green and the world just stopped.

Everything and everyone was still and frozen. Except for himself.

There was a green colored light coming from him. It took a moment for Steve to realize it was his Stone. He held it carefully as he looked at it. Sure he had seen it glow before. Mostly for Peggy but right now it was shining.

Out of the corner of his eye, Steve could see other lights of different colors. Around Thor was a deep blue. Tony was glowing orange. Natasha was glowing red while Bruce was purple. Clint was a little different. He wasn't all the way covered by his light, a very pale yellow haze that was almost not there.

The Stone he was reaching for was on the other hand was glowing brightly, the same shade as the sun. And as Steve took in the room, that same shade was scattered around the space. Mostly at the back of the heads of Hydra's soldiers, it coated Loki's skin, it glowed at Zola's temples and it was a pulsing light within Bucky's metal arm.

A thought entered Steve's mind. His fingers tingled and a sword appeared. His actual Sword. Erskine. Solid, metal, the Stone glowing at the hilt.

Steve took a moment to look at it. He never thought that he would see it whole again like this. He also noted that the light of the Stone started to blink. Slowly at first then faster. When he looked back up at Bucky, he noticed he was moving.

Slowly but with each second passing faster, realizing that he didn't have much time left, Steve reached out with one hand. He grabbed the metal arm lifting it into the air. Looking at where the light was pulsing. Steve took a breath while swinging the Sword downward.

As soon as the arm had been disconnected Bucky dropped. Whispering out a "Stevie?" before passing out. As the noise of the room started to come back, Steve's own legs gave out on him. The power that had been so strong a moment ago was gone just as fast as it had come, taking the Captain's form with it.

Steve didn't mind being small again. Bucky was fine now, free.

The worst of it was over. Steve thought, as he tried to keep his eyes open.

Then Clint let out a blood curdling scream.

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Chapter 9: Coming Clean

Steve stormed into the Captain's Vault banging the door open as he went. Steve was so mad that he could feel the Captain's form trying to come out. He was more than a little pissed off about the events of the day before. Steve was also tired of the ever growing list of people that kept jerking him around. He was starting to feel like some kind of trained monkey.

So well trained that he would perform just as planned without supervision. Steve knew that part of the reason he was so mad

was that he never thought that Peggy would be added to the list of those that didn't trust him with the whole truth.

As Steve made his way into the depths of the room, he was prepared to have to call for Peggy to appear. He really wanted to scream. Or at the least punch something. But Peggy stood in the center of the room, glowing in the low light. "I felt it," she spoke simply as he drew closer.

"And what exactly did you feel?" he snapped back. It aggravated him that she stood so calmly. "I felt that all the Stones were together and reacting." When Peggy said the word, reacting, her whole form went blurry.

It was something that Steve had never seen her do. For a brief moment Steve was scared that she would disappear for good and then he would never get his answers.

His temper flared at the thought. "It was more than just reacting. When Clint touched his Stone, it didn't recognize him. The bond between Zola and the Stone was so strong. Bruce went to pull Clint away because he was screaming in pain. But instead they both glowed with this purple and yellow light." Steve had to pause and swallow the bile that was rising in his throat at the thought.

"It was like something took a hold of them." Steve shook his head a little at the images. "There was a shift in power. Zola started to scream and all the Hydra soldiers were screaming right behind him. Each of them gripping their heads. We watched as Zola fell to the ground, his body contorting in pain. The soldiers started dropping one by one after him. And Clint and Bruce, their bodies were crackling. None of us were sure what to do until Loki started yelling that it would take all of us as one to calm the Stone." Steve remembered being so scared. Loki had done some type of magic that had put the room in a bubble. He said it was to try to contain the effects before it got out of hand.

Then Steve had taken Tony's hand and he felt stronger. And then Natasha took his other hand and Thor took Tony's and it was like

Steve had become a part of them. "We stepped forward and took hold of Clint and Bruce. For a brief second it felt like the Stone was going to fight us all. And then it just changed and it felt like home," Steve finished. He left out that it felt like something had been missing all this time. That he was finally whole.

When Sam had pulled them apart, it had felt weird to separate. To come back to himself and be just Steve not multiple creatures. By then Loki was gone. Zola was dead, his brain melted away. And Pierce, he had been stabbed. They were unsure if the Stone had made him do it since some of the other soldiers had stabbed themselves too to stop the pain. Or if Loki had done it. Either way Pierce was dead too.

Peggy made a humming noise before saying. "Yes, well, that is to be expected. The Mind Stone is one of the stronger out of the six Infinity Stones. It takes someone of a strong will and mind to control it."

Steve cocked his head. He had never heard that term before. "The Stone of Waverly is an Infinity Stone?" He asked. Peggy made a face. "It has always been, it was just where it was stored." Steve's brows knitted as he thought. "And the other Stones that the Avengers possess?"

"Yes they are Infinity Stones too," Peggy said, cutting him off. "You knew that the Stones were more than just power boosters? That they were capable of manipulating people?! "The anger was back again.

It seemed that all Steve was doing nowadays was staying angry. "Yes, I knew. The Infinity Stones are the responsibility of the Captain since they together form the ultimate weapon. A weapon capable of granting any wish of the User. If the User is strong enough. It never occurred to me that the Avengers would ever be strong enough to be able to use its powers. And you, Steve, just never seemed to have the want for such costly power," Peggy had said it softly but it still hurt.

There were so many questions. And if they were going to end this war they needed the answers.

"Start from the top. I want to know everything about the Infinity Stones." Steve said as he took a seat on the ground. Peggy huffed but sat too before she spoke.

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When she was done talking Steve already had a plan. But first they would need to call the whole planet to arms. And then they would need to work on using the Stones' power. For that they would need a dear old friend.

Steve just hoped that Thor's knack for finding Loki was still working.

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Chapter 10 : Preparations and Homecomings

Steve was reviewing the newest information sent by a group of fighters called the Guardians of the Galaxy. A motley group that included a tree, a raccoon, a deadpan fighter, an empath, a space pirate with a passion for setting his own ship on fire and two siblings. Gamora and Nebula. Daughters of Thanos. Who were now on the side of S.H.I.E.L.D..

The Guardians were currently tracking Thanos' fleet, a slow task since when the sisters escaped their group took all of Thanos' Hyper Drive systems from his whole fleet. From their reports Tony was able to calculate that Thanos would be in range of Midgard in less than a month. It was a little worrying but now that they knew more about the stones it made preparing for battle easier.

Right now, Steve was the only one in the war room. Tony was in his lab fitting new armor for Clint and Sam. Nat and Bruce were meeting with Odin about getting ready for the battles to come.

Thor had gone North to recruit the Jotuns. With the army that Thanos would be bringing, the Avengers had been doing a lot of recruiting over the past months.

And Bucky was also in Tony's lab to see how the new arm was coming along. A task that Steve had a hard time letting Bucky do alone. Since Bucky was cleared by medical he had either been listening to his messages, talking to Peggy or in the corner of whatever room Steve was in.

It depended on how Bucky was feeling as to how he would act. Sometimes he would be semi-normal and even voice things such as improvements to the plans. Other times he just stared blankly at Steve. And while Steve had always wanted Bucky to look at him, this was not the way he had hoped to have Bucky's eyes on him. It was breaking Steve's heart.

But Bucky's interest in the arm and training was the only time Bucky was really animated and alive. And Steve didn't want to stand in the way of that. His friends had told him that hobbies helped with healing. And there was nothing more Steve wanted than for Bucky to heal. So when Bucky left to go to the lab Steve had given him a hug and told him to be safe and make sure to voice to Tony if anything hurt. Bucky had given him a small smile which made Steve's heart flutter.

There was a knock at the war room door startling Steve a little. "It's open." Steve called from where he stood pinning notes to the board. Some of the notes he had to jump to get them where they needed to be. Being short sometimes was a real pain.

The door creaked open letting in a very tired looking Thor. Steve wished he could send Thor off to rest but there was still a lot of work to do. "How did it go?" Steve asked as he gathered more papers. "It went well. King Laufey has promised his aid as well as soldiers. He is gathering them as we speak." Thor relayed the news with sleepy eyes. "Good." Steve said, placing a blue pin on the map where the capital of Jotunheim was.

Having the ice giants would be a huge boost to the Rebellion's forces. And if King Laufey brought the Casket of Winters it could bring their side a huge advantage. Steve quickly scribbled on a scrap piece of paper to mention the Casket the next time they talked to the frost King.

"There is something else." Thor said hastily, making Steven pause. "Good or bad?" Steve questioned as he looked up. His mind was already trying to think of how he was going to fix whatever this was that Thor was going to be telling him about. "It's good I suppose." Thor said, taking a deep breath before continuing. "King Laufey said that the Casket of Winter had picked up attempts at magic in the northern wilderness. He said that he believes it is his son Loki."

Steve perked up at the news. Loki had disappeared without a trace after the final battle. They needed him desperately. A lot of Steve's plan was built around having Loki around. "Did the King know where Loki was exactly?" They needed to get to Loki and talk to him as soon as they could. Get him back here and briefed. "No, but I think I can find him." Thor said. His voice made Steve sure that he could.

"Ok, I think Sam and Clint can go with you." Steve started to say but Thor was shaking his head no. "I think it is best if I go alone. Besides, I need to talk to him privately." Thor said solemnly. Steve watched Thor carefully for a second. Thor was always the one that Loki responded to better.

Loki had already been talked about in several meetings over the past weeks. His case argued back and forth from everyone. But in the end it was both Steve and Bucky's argument that the Avengers should at least hear Loki out about what he had to say first. That if the others gave Steve and Bucky a second chance it was only fair that Loki got one too. Steve didn't know Loki as long as the others but he did know that Loki didn't do things without reason.

"Ok." Steve said in agreement. "If Loki won't come I won't make him. I also talked to my father and King Laufey, both of them agree with me." Thor stated. There was fire in his words. Steve knew that Thor was willing to fight them all over this. "Very well. If Loki won't come I will think of something else. But I think you won't fail us. You'll bring him home. He belongs with his family." Steve does his best to express how much he believes in Thor. Thor looked relieved as he stood and moved to the door. "I will do my best." Thor said as he exited.

And really at this point that is all they can do.
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Steve ducked down behind an outcropping of rocks where he was pinned down. He was kind of cursing himself for taking the Captain's form in this battle. If he was small he would be able to cover himself more. Bucky was a foot to Steve's right while Sam was to Steve's left. "Do you see the enemy?" Sam said. Redwing his personal drone had been shot out of the sky early in the battle. A simple mistake of Sam forgetting to put the cloaking on.

The others were out in the field. Tony and Clint were leading the new recruits that arrived in Asgard a week ago. They were doing well against Ebony Maw. If the current group continued to do well, then they could advance to fighting more than one of Thanos' children like Steve, Bucky and Sam were doing.

Currently they were only fighting two children. Steve couldn't remember their names just they were two of the meaner ones. This was more of a cool down for the Avengers (sans Thor) had a battle earlier with Thanos. One that they barely pulled off a win against. Which didn't make Steve happy since this wasn't even the real thing.

The thing about the Reality Stone was that it was incredibly realistic depending on what the wielder was going for. And Natasha now that she had gotten the hang of it was very determined. She poured over all the footage and records of Thanos' previous battles. Recreating them as best she could.

So far they have run simulations based on the reports. If it was just the Avengers, they had worked out a way to attach the Reality Stone to the core in the Captain's Vault. Tony had used some big words on how he did it, then smaller words and then just told them not to worry about it. Steve's only concerned if it would damage Peggy's program.

Tony had waved it off and said "Nope, Pops had done something with the Soul Stone to design Peggy. I am still figuring it out." The growl in Tony's voice clued Steve into how much that it really bothered Tony that Howard had one-upped his son. Steve had no doubt that Tony would figure it out. It was probably something simple. While Peggy had known a lot about the other stones, the soul stone was powerful and the most mysterious out of the set so it meant that Tony didn't get to use it much in these battles.

But that didn't stop Tony from fighting. Even though Natasha wasn't making it easy. Since the Captain's Vault was not big enough for a full battle with an army and wouldn't let outsiders in, troop training had to be held outside. The field chosen for today's battles was rocky and hard to move about. It also had some alteration made up by the Reality Stone.

In other words, this was more than a little aggravating. Sighing, Steve turned back to where the shooting was coming from, preparing to throw his shield.

"Something is coming." Bucky yelled out, catching Steve's attention. There was a small dark mass flying from the West from the ever expanding camp towards them. And fast. "What is that?" Sam asked, narrowing his eyes as it got closer. "A crow." Bucky said softly, watching it with sharp eyes.

The bird let out a sharp aching caw that seemed to crackle in the air. Steve straightened up. "It's one of Odin's Ravens," Natasha said, appearing next to Steve. As the Raven circled above them, the illusions that Natasha had been projecting started to fade away.

By the time the bird had landed on a nearby rock, Tony and Clint had made it up to the rest of the group. The Raven studied them with a roll of parchment tied to its leg. "So who is going to get him?" Clint asked. A chorus of not I's shot back. Odin's Ravens while they did their jobs were little Assholes that were not above trying to peck whoever they were sent to relay messages to.

"I'll get him," Bucky said. His claws already coming out, his tail shifting from casual sway to hunting stiff mode. "Don't hurt him," Steve got out. "Too much," Tony added on. Bucky dropped into a crouch with a tightly hissed "No promises." The Raven bounced in a circle.

But in a flash of brown and a few squawks, the bird was caught. It was impressively fast considering that Bucky was still without his left arm. Tony was still making the recalibration to it. Steve tried to stay focused. Having Bucky fighting beside him was both a distraction and a comfort. And at times Steve found it hard to keep his eyes from studying everything he had missed about Bucky's body.

With the Raven now caught, Steve stepped forward to retrieve the message.

Once the message was secured, Bucky released the bird. It gave them all a few short shouts before taking to the air.

No one really paid any attention to it. They all watched as Steve unrolled the paper to read it. "What's it say?" Tony asked. And Steve had to smile. "Thor is back," Steve said, smiling as he looked up. "And what about Loki?" Sam asked for the rest of the team. "Thor says Loki is making us all his famous perk-me-up potion as we speak."

The cheers from his friends lifted Steve's soul. They needed this last thing.

He needed this too. Now with Loki back he could finalize his battle plans.

They could win this, Steve thought. And for the first time he really believed it.

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Chapter 11: Will you fight by my side as our world ends

"Can there be peace? We don't want a meaningless battle," Steve asked firmly. He knew it was a stupid thing to ask. But if there was any chance of saving lives, he would do it.

Thanos stood towering over them all. Even currently being in his Captain form Thanos had a few feet on Steve. Most of the Avengers had been against this meeting on the battlefield. But Gamora's reports had stated, "Thanos may be trying to conquer the universe but he is a stickler for tradition and balance. He won't deny your request."

And he hadn't. Agreeing to meet in the uninhabited part of the planet. The table had been placed at the center of the battlefield. Chairs for both sides which no one took. They had given him the body of Pierce. And tried to talk terms.

It was becoming clear that while Thanos did offer the Avengers a chance to speak. He wasn't changing his plans for the Stones. Luckily they had been smart enough not to bring them.

"The only path to peace is through this final battle. When this is all over, when I have purged the universe, that is when true peace and balance can begin," Thanos' deep voice boomed. Tony frowned as they all took a step back from the table. "Very well then, your funeral," Tony shot back. Thanos gave them a nod before he turned with his Children who were acting as Thanos' Generals, moving back to his side of the field.

"So any chance we can skip the theatrics?" Loki asked as he stepped out of the portal that had appeared by their side. "Nope, the purple butthole wants to fight," Clint groused. Loki frowned

but moved between them handing out the Stones. "Well, everything is in order above. The cloaking spell is holding. The S.H.I.E.L.D. space fleet is hidden and waiting for the order to attack," Loki reported.

Each of the members gave their own sign that they heard Loki. Most of them were already thinking of the battle ahead of them. Steve was focused on Bucky's face.

Bucky was standing at the front next to King Odin. The newly fitted metal arm, a rush job, gleamed in the sunlight. Steve had told Bucky that if he had wanted to he could be with one of the other platoons.

There was no illusion that this battle was going to be over in no time. They had plenty of units and platoons waiting for their chance. But Bucky had given a tiny quirk of his lips and said, "And leave you by yourself with all that stupid. Yeah, I don't think so."

Seeing Bucky now even with those ears flattened like that and his tail unnervingly still helped to calm Steve. In Bucky's hands were his old weapons, the double batons. Like the Sword, Bucky's batons had the ability to change forms providing Bucky with whatever weapon he may need. "So, I am assuming that they aren't giving up?" Bucky asked when Steve took his place beside him. "Not exactly,." Steve replied. Bucky sighed, "Didn't think it would be that easy." Steve gave a small smile of his own. "You know you want a chance at some payback," Steve stated.

Bucky cocked his head, ears giving a little bob. "I suppose I do." To the left somewhere a horn sounded, letting everyone know the battle was about to start. Steve should have been scared or at least nervous but with Bucky at his side he felt ready for anything.

After all a Captain was nothing without his Sergeant. Steve thought as he readied his weapon.

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Steve didn't know what day it was. He had lost track after the ships had dropped from the sky. It had been part of the plan. Thor plus the Guardians had used the Space Stone to travel into each of Thanos' ships. They placed some kind of device that Tony had made into each one.

It had caused the ships to slip out of formation. Once they were moved into position over Thanos' main base camp, they fell. The atmosphere of the planet helped to break them up into smaller parts.

Sadly, Thanos survived that just fine. His Children were another story, though. Ebony Maw had faced off against Tony and Bruce. They were able to pull out a win with the help of the Power Stone.

Natasha and Clint had won against Proxima Midnight. Sam and Loki killed Corvus Glaive. Bucky and Steve had gone up against Cull Obsidian.

The information that Nebula and Gamora had been able to give on their ex-siblings and all the practice battles had been just what they needed to help with each of their victories.

The losses however didn't stop the fighting. It seemed to increase it.

Steve knew that some of the Avengers, particularly Tony, were leaning towards using the Stones together to end this. Something that Steve was strongly against. Peggy had told him that none of the Captains or Sergeants that used the full power of the Stones had survived.

There was also the fact that it could have unseen consequences if the wish was not clear. Wishing to get rid of the enemy could mean the disappearance of a whole planet with all its inhabitants. Good and bad included.

Clint had said, "The pain of my Stone was so much. I could hear every voice that was connected to the Stone and all their screams.

I vaguely remember just wishing for all the minds to shut up. And the Stone complied by liquefying their brains."

It was enough to put the talk of using the Stones to a low murmur. But Steve knew every time that he rested curled into Bucky, with each passing day and the rising death count, that more people were starting to want to take the risk.

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"Tony!" Steve screamed. But he was too far. Thanos however was within range, his giant blade raised. Steve hadn't even known that Thanos was this far behind their lines. None of the reports had mentioned it. Yet there he was.

There was a second before the blade came whistling down only to be stopped by an orange lighted figure of a person. Steve had to squint his eyes before he realized what he was seeing.

Rhodey was standing there in some kind of metal suit. And he wasn't the only one. Next to him was Maria and Frigga. All glowing that same pale light. The same light that Peggy glowed. There was a thought starting to form. An idea of what Howard might have done to create that so-called memory of Peggy.

"Steve, we got to go," Bucky hissed out as he darted by. As Steve moved to follow, he saw why it was so urgent. The souls that were appearing to help Tony were only taking two or three hits from Thanos' sword before falling apart in blasts of light.

Tony countered that by calling more and more souls. And while it was slowing Thanos down, it was not stopping him. It was also draining Tony. And fast, by the look of how he slumped between his mother and Peter.

Steve also could tell by how much distance they still needed to cover that they wouldn't make it. They needed a portal or the Asgardian Stone. Both Thor and Loki were helping with the space fleet.

If Tony could stall just a little longer, Natasha could make it to him.

Just as Steve opened his mouth to tell Tony they were coming, Thanos had smashed through the last two souls. He went for Peter, throwing him across the field. Maria was crushed by a foot. Steve braced for the sight of Tony being crushed as well, only Thanos just picked him up and took the Stone from the armor that Tony wore.

With the Stone in hand Tony was dropped to the side. There was only a brief second before Natasha was there with Clint right behind her. They both attacked as one.

Only… and Steve almost stopped when he realized that Thanos was somehow stronger.

They had all had brief contact with Thanos over the past couple of weeks and of course the training but something had changed just now.

Both Clint and Natasha seemed to realize it too. Though it was too late. A well aimed punch to Clint's stomach and he was down. Natasha however was a little harder but once she was alone in the fight, she was distracted by Clint's prone body.

Nat went down after a punch to her leg. Steve heard the crack from how far away he was. Bucky dropped short when Natasha went down. "Steve, hold up," he said as he grabbed hold of Steve's arm. "What Bucky, we got to help them. We can't just leave our friends," Steve yelled as he tried to shake Bucky off him.

Bucky didn't listen though he held on tighter, his nails digging into Steve's skin. In front of them the Hulk let out a battle cry. "Yes, we need to help them but not this way. You can't see it because you're blinded by your group bond. I don't have that restriction. I see this for what it is. A trap."

Bucky's words were still ringing in the air when the ground trembled under them. The Hulk let out a bellow that was cut off

suddenly.

Steve felt something tug within him as he tried to get around Bucky. There was a chant in his head, 'Must get to the others.' That wouldn't stop.

It kept getting louder.

"Steve!" Bucky yelled but Steve could barely hear him over the chant. There was a sharp pain across Steve's cheeks that brought him back to himself. "Stevie," Bucky said. "Please hear me." Tears were welling in his eyes. The pain had pushed back the chant to a low hum in the back of Steve's mind.

"Bucky," he whispered. He wanted to say more but the side of his face stung when he talked. Bucky's claws must have been out. "We need to think about this," Bucky said, voice growing louder to be heard over the loud whistling that was coming from above. Steve couldn't hear what Bucky said after that, only saw his mouth moving. Steve watched as Bucky looked up. Horror all over his face.

Steve looked up too. There was something coming through the atmosphere. A giant cloud crackling with lightning was speeding towards the field. Steve didn't know much about asteroids or comets. But he did know that it was coming at them too fast for them to run. Both he and Bucky hit the ground, covering their heads right before impact.

Only when the ground stopped shaking and the bits of debris stopped raining down on them did they look up. Through the cloud of dust, Steve could barely make out something moving ahead of him. It's only when it stood back up that Steve realized that it was Thanos.

And he now had the Asgardian Stone.

Steve stood.

He wasn't sure what he was going to do but he needed to do something. His friends were hurt. There was only one Stone left.

And more importantly he was the Captain. The Stones were his responsibility.

'Come to me, little one,' Thanos' voice called in Steve's head. 'Come be with your friends.' Steve took one step on shaky legs before Bucky was in front of him. "I know what you're trying to do but you can't, Steve." Bucky's eyes were wide and wild as he kept looking back over his shoulder at where Thanos stood. "You don't understand, Bucky. I caused this all. I brought him to our planet. This is all my fault and I have to fix it." Steve tried to push Bucky back but Bucky remained in place.

"There is always another way. It doesn't always have to be you?" Bucky huffed out, his ears flattening against his head in anger. It was kind of cute but Steve didn't dare say it. He would take that to his grave. Which might not be too long from now. "I need to do this, Buck. I got to do my part like everyone else." Steve knew Bucky had to understand. It had been Steve's drive, his push since they were kids.

A thirst to prove that he was worthy to be chosen. That he wasn't a spare. And then that had turned into a need to show that the Sword didn't pick him by accident. Steve had hoped that Bucky would nod his head and let him do this. But instead it seemed to make Bucky more furious. "Why are you like this? Why does it always have to be you? When do you get to choose?" It was a question that Steve had said to himself several times already. And he never had a solid answer for them.

Instead Steve whispered in a voice full of fear, "Let me go, Buck. Please."

Steve watched as Bucky relaxed in a sad sort of way. "I can't do that Stevie. I won't let you kill yourself, not when I can help. Remember, You and me forever. Till the end of the line." There was a small bit of disappointment in Bucky's voice as if he wasn't

sure that Steve was getting the full meaning of what he was saying.

"I failed, Buck," Steve admitted. Still fighting the pull that had Steve wanting to run to Thanos.

Bucky shook his head. "You have never given up on anything. And I am not asking you too. What I am saying is that it is okay to ask for help," Bucky said as he pulled Steve into a hug. He softly kissed Steve's forehead. "Do you trust me, my Love?" Bucky asked. His words were so soft.

And Steve didn't think as he replied back, "With all of my soul." Bucky tipped Steve's head up giving him a kiss to the lips. It was short but it held a promise of more to come if they got out of this mess. Bucky stepped back a small smile on his lips as he placed a hand on Steve's chest. "Good. Go get your friends," he hissed out.

Steve barely understood what was happening as he fell backwards. There was also a tug from within him, like he was being pulled in half. Looking into Bucky's clawed hand, Steve understood why. Bucky had taken his Stone. It glowed green in his hands. "Sorry," Bucky said as he turned to walk toward Thanos.

Steve went to get up, struggling at the sudden shift back to his normal body. He only paused when he heard something clinking as it hit the ground. There was a small bag sitting at Steve's feet. Picking it up, Steve peered inside to see that it had six vials. Each written with Loki's neat handwriting, 'Healing draft.'

"Oh," Steve said before he took off towards the crater where Thor lay.

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Chapter 12: We Fight Together.

Bucky moved towards Thanos at a confident walk. He could already hear Steve moving, sliding down towards Thor. Hopefully Thor was still alive and could drink the potion. Bucky's very simple kinda of sort of plan depended on all the Avengers being alive to back him up.

Not for the first time did Bucky curse the influence of that stupid blond punk on his life. His mother had always said Bucky had a nice level head on his shoulder. And Bucky probably wouldn't have been in this predicament if his younger self hadn't walked up to a crying Sarah Rogers right before takeoff and told her that he would keep an eye and an ear on her son. She had probably thought that Bucky was being a sweet kid. But Bucky had meant it.

It was why he always measured the risk in his mind and took the most dangerous position. Not that Steve ever noticed. Steve didn't seem to notice much, not even the fact that as they grew closer as friends through their training that Bucky was falling in love with him.

Peggy noticed of course. She noticed everything. She had told Bucky only once to be careful of his feelings. "They can make you stronger. But they can make a very painful target." Her eyes told Bucky that she had lost someone she loved in the past. And since he respected her as both his Captain and trainer, he didn't ask.

She had been right. Because here he was about to do something that would probably get him killed just so Steve could have the better chance at surviving.

Judging the distance Bucky stopped. He needed to make sure that Thor and Steve could get to the others while he distracted Thanos. Hoping this would work Bucky took a deep breath clearing his mind and letting his face go blank. It was time for his greatest acting job ever.

"Lord Thanos!" Bucky called, waiting for the alien to turn to him. When he had Thanos' eyes on him Bucky knelt holding the Stone

up as he bowed his head. "I have the Time Stone for you my Lord."

Thanos grinned at Bucky as he made his way over. "I know you. My grandson sent me your details. The one that was trained under Captain Carter and that Doctor Zola was able to show the truth." Bucky held his position unmoving besides his ears.

His ears had always been his greatest strength. That knew every sound that Steve made and what it meant. Right now Steve was to Bucky's right. He was making his way towards Stark. Thor was on Bucky's left side crawling through the low shrubs to where Bruce was sprawled in the dirt. Both of them had the sound of vials knocking against each other coming from them.

Thanos came to a stop standing above Bucky. "Rise," he said after a beat. Bucky did so as slowly as he could. He knew that he was running out of time. The next part of the plan would all depend on how long he could hold on. And for that Bucky was going to have to wait until the last minute to make his move

"Zola had said you would be the greatest of all his creations and look at you able to sneak back to the Avengers. Made them believe that you were still loyal to them. It is impressive." There was a pause as Thanos looked Bucky over. Bucky did his very best to stand still and give nothing away.

After a moment, Thanos spoke again. "You deserve a reward. Come forward. Let me see who it is you care about the most and I will use the mind Stone to make them as you are. You can fight side by side for as long as you both shall live." Thanos held a hand out. It was covered in a golden glove. This was where the Stones laid.

They sparkled on the surface. The Stone of Waverly was glowing a warm dangerous yellow.

Bucky knew his moment had come. Giving a quick thought to Steve as Bucky raised the Time Stone activating it just as it was

about to touch the metal.

Green light spilled around Thanos freezing him in the moment. Bucky had only a few seconds before the power of the Time Stone started burning him. The cost of someone other than the Captain using its powers.

Bucky had to hang on.

Steve wouldn't let him down. Bucky knew it in his heart. He just had to stay strong and focus.

There was a flare of purple light just as Bucky realized the flaw in his time bubble. He had left himself out so that he could better control the spell. But in doing so the bubble bent around his form. Leaving the Stones uncovered. And with the mind Stone already activated, the connection between Thanos and the Stones was still active.

Meaning, and Bucky had to swallow at the thought, that Thanos could use the Stones to attack the Time Stone and whomever was touching it. Bucky had enough time to brace before the pain hit him and he screamed.

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Steve had just fed Clint his vial of potion when Bucky started screaming. "Thanos can still use the Stones," said Tony from where he fidgeted at Steve's side. Steve took one look at Tony's wide eyes before looking back to Bucky. Bucky was still standing in the same spot but his skin was flashing with the colors of the Stones. "You can still feel your Stone?" Steve asked.

"A little. I think we are still connected to the Stones," Clint said as he sat up. He wasn't moving as smoothly as he normally did. Sometimes depending on how bad the injury was, it took a bit more time to heal. "From what I am feeling, he doesn't know we are being healed. He is only focused on James," Natasha said as Thor and Bruce led her over.

Steve tried to focus on forming a plan and not Bucky's screams of pain. "We need to separate that glove and get you guys your Stones back," Steve said. Tony's eyes narrowed a little in thought. "Any ideas?" Tony asked. Steve thought for a moment then said, "If we can attack at once, and together as soon as the time spell comes down we should be able to end this."

"I can separate the Stones," Thor said, summoning his weapon, a battle ax. "I will get the Stone from Bucky and hold Thanos still," said Steve. "And we can do the rest," Bruce said. They all looked at one another. There was an understanding.

Something that came from being a team.

From having a deep trust in one another.

In being a family,

"Ok then," Steve said. "On three," Thor said.

And Tony counted down.
…

"Hell yeah!!" Tony shouted. Only for them all to groan as the smoke started to clear. Thanos was still standing. Not as straight as he had been but he was standing. "I take back my hell yeah," Tony said as he struggled to get into a fighting stance. They were all at their wits end.

"I will not be beaten by a bunch of misfits," Thanos said as he took a step forward. He was staggering, his balance off since Thor had chopped off Thanos' arm to get the stones. But he still had his weapon. Thanos wasn't going to stop.

Steve could tell by looking at his team that there wasn't anything left in them. Steve was in the same boat, the Captain wasn't coming forth although Steve could feel that there was still some power left even if his body wasn't going to hold out much longer. Steve knew that there was only one thing left to do.

Without another thought, he snatched Natasha's Stone from her hands. He counted himself lucky that they all still had their Stones out after that last attack. Darting forward, Steve activated the Time Stone. He could hear the others call his name but he didn't stop. He was doing this for them, for everyone.

Thanos swung his weapon but Steve was ready. The power burned as time froze.

Taking a shaky step forward, Steve placed a hand on Thanos. Grabbing at the Captain's power he focused it on the Reality Stone. Thinking as clearly as possible Steve thought of a universe without Thanos.

Beneath Steve the world shifted and went black.

…

It felt as if Steve was floating weightless and numb. Slowly a light appeared next to him.

It was Peggy. "Am I dead?" Steve asked. "No Darling. But very close to it. Did you have to be so reckless?" she asked sadly. "I didn't see any other choice. You said the Captain could wield the stones," Steve replied back. His fingers and toes were starting to tingle.

"Yes, the Captain can, but you weren't transformed yet. You weren't the Captain all the way," Peggy said carefully. "And what does that mean?" Steve shot back. He was going to say more but pain started to race through his body. "It means that using your power the way you did has burned your connection to the Captain's powers," Peggy said slowly. There was something pulling Steve. Calling his name. But he fought it. He needed to ask something important. "Does that mean that I can't be the Captain ever again?"

"Perhaps, maybe one day. When your connection heals. But what I think is more important is that you figure out how to be Steven again," Peggy smiled as she spoke. Steve blinked slowly. The

darkness was gone and with it Peggy. Standing above him was his team. All glowing with the light of their stones. "He's back," Loki said somewhere near Steve's head.

At his words the others stopped glowing, slowly sinking to the ground. Natasha was the first to open her eyes. "Don't you ever do that again, Steve. You scared us," she said to him with unfocused eyes. "You guys brought me back," Steve slurred out. "Of course we did. You're an Avenger and while you seemed to keep forgetting, we are a team. So no dying today," Clint said.

Steve was going to say something else but Loki interrupted. "You guys don't look too hot. Who needs a lift to the infirmary?" Loki asked, eyes scanning over each of them.

Stark let out a low "I reinstate my hell yeah." Before he passed out. Steve slumped over onto Bruce letting out a chuckle that turned into a full blown laugh. A few of the others joined in. Though Steve couldn't tell if it was because they were in pain or just as relieved as he was.

They were free.

And it was over.

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Epilogue: To The Future

Steve stared around the enormous ballroom with a detached sort of interest.

It wasn't that the party was boring or anything. Thor had already performed some kind of dance of his Homeland on the center table. Then of course Tony had a little too much to drink and had belted out a few songs with Clint. Steve was sure most of those songs were made up.

There was no way that there were that many songs about being friends. And Steve was sure he never heard any songs that went: it's fun to be friends with friends.

But Steve couldn't blame everyone.

Hydra was finally defeated. Finally, after all these centuries of fighting and people that had given their lives for the cause, it was over.

Relief and freedom had lifted the weight off of everyone making them light and happy in a way Steve never thought he would get to see in his lifetime. The moment Hydra was destroyed the future had been opened up to some many possibilities.

Sure the universe was a mess. A lot of planets needed help. And there were still minor heads of Hydra out there. But Fury was already working on that. So that meant the Avengers could rest and figure out what they wanted to do next.

For Steve there was only one path he wanted to take. One person he really cared about making a future with. The problem was that he had no clue if they wanted to do the same back.

Steve knew he was being a bit of a mood killer. His somber mood came off of him in a fog that brought down anyone that was in range. Which was why he was now holding up in a corner. He had been holding his gloomy vigil by the punch bowl but even with how polite the others were acting Steve could tell that he was 1: Not helping. And 2: Leaving the majority of the room thirsty.

It wasn't that Steve was trying to bring down the mood. It was just. Well Bucky wasn't here.

The final battle hadn't been good to Bucky as it had been to Steve. Bucky had been in recovery since the battle. And Steve had gone a few times to the infirmary but Bucky hadn't been awake. Which meant no way to talk about what had happened. What had been said. Which just left Steve on edge and irritable.

Steve wanted to know if Bucky meant what he said. He wanted to tell Bucky that he had always felt the same. So much of the future that Steve had always dreamed about, that he always wanted was within his reach.

Yet with one word from Bucky it could all dissipate before it had truly set.

"Oh my god, Steve, if you don't stop with the angst. It's like some kind of gas attack. I swear you're trying to kill me," Tony groused from where Natasha had dumped him to cool off an hour ago. Steve spared a look at the man. Tony was slumped against the wall, looking out at the dance floor. There was a slight wistful look to his face as he watched the others.

Tony had lost a lot from Hydra's attack campaign. His parents. His home. His loved ones. In some ways he was like Steve. No real place to go now. But there were now infinite possibilities open to them.

Steve sighed he would probably need to get Tony some water or something in a minute.

Steve wasn't quite sure how it became his job to have to look after Tony. It wasn't like he was Tony's only friend. Besides, didn't their group like to do the whole no Avenger left behind. Steve was starting to think it only applied in battle or dangerous situations.

The others probably figured it would be best to give Steve something to hold his attention so he wouldn't do something stupid. Steve had to say they weren't wrong.

"Sorry, Tony, do you want me to get you anything?" Steve asked. He glanced at the punch bowl to see how crowded it was. He didn't want to send people running again.

Tony let out a loud huff that pulled Steve's eyes to him. "What I want, Steve," Tony said, squinting up at him. "Is for you and Barnes to stop dancing around the bush. I want you to tell him how you feel. And then I want you to pull that bush from the

ground so that we can hold a bonfire around it." Tony finished with his fire explosion gesture. It was a little sloppy but Steve blamed the drinks.

Steve pushed down the familiar fear that the whole team knew how bad his longing for Bucky was. Taking a breath Steve tried to put out the fire in his cheeks.

"My apologies, Tony. I promise to get right on that as soon as I see Bucky again," Steve said honestly. "You mean that?" Tony asked seriously. "Of course I do," Steve replied back quickly. "On the oh-so-glamorous soul of Peggy Carter and your Stone?" Tony questioned.

Giving a genuine smile, Steve stated, "On all that and more." Meaning every word of it. Tony studied him for a moment. He seemed to be satisfied as he looked back to the dance floor. "Good, cause your boy is right there. So get to it," Tony ordered.

Steve, despite knowing that Tony was probably seeing things, looked out at the floor. It was packed and full of color which Steve would blame for how long it took him to see it. But when he did it took his breath away. Bucky was indeed here.

He stood next to Loki. Both the ex-Hydra slaves were dressed elegantly for the party. Loki in the colors of his homeland dark greens and golds while his skin was that ice blue that made Steve cold just looking at it. Bucky on the other hand was dressed in a yummy plum color purple. The suit was form fitting but made more relaxed by Bucky leaving the jacket unbuttoned and the tie hanging around his neck.

The pair seemed to be having a conversation. From the looks of Bucky's posture it wasn't a heavy topic. In fact Steve thought as he took a slower look over Bucky's form he looked relaxed. But there was a slight tension in the way his tail swung and the constant twist of Bucky's ears that told Steve that Bucky was waiting for something to happen. But not a threat since the metal hand was loose and open, not balled up in a fist.

"What did I just say, Rogers?" Tony said loudly, causing Steve to jump. "What?" Steve snapped back as he took his eyes off of Bucky. "I said Nat and Thor are coming over. You can go fulfill your promise. That is if you're not too chicken," Tony added. "I am not," Steve said, straightening his stance.

"Prove it," Tony snarked back. He knew that Steve was hardly one to back down from a challenge. "Fine. I will," Steve said, brushing himself off and tidying his outfit. "Good," Tony shouted as Steve walked away. "Ok!" Steve shouted over his shoulder.

He passed by Natasha and Thor as he made his way to the other side of the room. As he moved he tried to think of what to say. There was always "Hey Buck, good to see you awake." But that didn't cover everything that Steve was feeling. Then there was "You look good. How's the arm treating you?" But then that would bring up all the bad things that had happened. And that was not where Steve wanted to start the conversation at.

Steve sighed as he realized that he would just go with the wing it approach and hope that it would turnout for the best. With his mind made up he attempted to school his face into a softer look. He didn't need Bucky taking one look at his face and getting all skittish and running away.

That train of thought made things even worse. Now he was angry at Hydra all over again. They took Steve's cocky flirty best guy and turned him into someone that feared his own shadow at times. It made Steve sick.

"Oh dear, who pissed you off this time?" Came Loki's cool voice. Steve looked up to see that he had arrived at his destination. Or at least sort of. Bucky was not here. Looking back over the hall, Steve spotted Bucky. He was now standing beside Gamora. They were both watching as Sam, Clint and Starlord (Peter Quill) as they launched into a dancing version of Friends with Friends. It was in fact worse than when they were only singing it.

With a sigh, Steve headed off that way. "You're not going to start a fight are you? This is supposed to be a party, not a fighting match," Loki called after him. Steve this time kept his eyes mostly on Bucky. He only briefly stopped when a tray of his favorite mini apple tarts passed by with one of the waiters.

(It was U, one of Tony's robots. The safer out of the three. Dum-E was trying to give out hot chocolate mixed with motor oil.)

Steve had grabbed four of the tasty treats only to look up and Bucky was once again gone. It took Steve five minutes to find Bucky again. This time he was dancing with Wanda. They looked like they were having such a good time that Steve decided to wait until the song was over to corner Bucky.

But just like the time before, as soon as the song was over and the dancefloor crowded with the next set of couples, Bucky had disappeared with a flick of a tail.

A half an hour of playing hide and seek with Bucky had Steve standing on the balcony alone. After the last miss, Steve had come out here. It felt like Bucky was running on purpose. And the ballroom was starting to take notice of the entertainment.

Steve should have known better. Bucky was good at hiding. Even when they were kids, Bucky was the champion of that particular game. Getting more skilled as he aged. The time spent with Hydra only just honed his skills even more.

Sighing Steve stared up at the stars. He prayed to his ancestors for help and guidance. It would be the least that they could do after everything his people had done to him. And to Bucky. But then again, because they were chosen they were alive. So maybe it was Steve that owed them.

A blast of noise behind Steve let him know that someone had joined him out here. Steve frowned; he wasn't in the mood for company. The noisy interruption only darkened his mood. His friends were having a great time, some were even pairing off. And

then there was him. Out here on the edge of their light with nothing but unrequited feelings for his best friend and anger for an enemy long dead.

He was a joke.

"What's so fascinating that it got you out here in the dark instead of inside with all your friends Punk?" Bucky's voice rang loud in the otherwise quiet. It was only a few words but it did wonders for Steve's soul. In a few heartbeats Steve’s breathing had evened out and he calmed.

Bucky often had that effect on him. "Not all of them are my friends, Jerk. Besides you're out here now so that means not all of my friends are inside anymore," Steve countered. He still looked at the sky. He wasn't ready to face Bucky yet. Steve was sort of afraid that if he did it would be something his mind made up.

"I don't know, Pal," Bucky said as he moved next to Steve. There was a scrape of glass as Bucky slid a champagne flute towards him. "I am not that important," Bucky said offhandedly. At that Steve turned to look at him. Bucky was sipping at the drink with a small sad smile on his face. Steve knew then that Bucky really believed what he just said.

Steve's inner fire was relit. Picking up the glass, Steve threw it back, drinking it in one go. When it was empty he slammed it down on the ledge. When the burn of the liquor cleared, he took a step forward. Bucky looked at him with interest which was better than him making a run for it. "Bucky, I know that Hydra did a lot to you and that there is a lot that you are still trying to make sense of but you are more dear to me than anything in this world." When Bucky tried to turn away, his cheeks flushed, Steve reached out tenderly to hold him still.

"I mean it, Pal. If I could I would give up all my powers, my stone and just be normal, boring me in a heartbeat if it would take away your pain," Steve stated but Bucky cut him off. "Don't put yourself down like that, Punk. That so-called boring part of you is who I

care about the most. Sure you being the Captain is cool. It suits you but just plain you, Stevie, is better than anything this world has to offer. So I don't want to hear another word against my best Fella you hear me?" Bucky said sternly.

Steve could only nod at the fire that was coming through loud and clear in those eyes and voice. It was a hint, a shadow of the old Bucky and it brought tears to Steve's eyes. He had begun to lose hope that his Bucky, the one he grew up with, the one he fell in love with would be lost to him forever. There were times when Bucky was quiet and distant. And then there were times when Bucky was like this. Steve should have known better. Bucky was a fighter like Steve, so impossible odds were what they were good at.

"Hey," Bucky said, much softer. "I didn't mean to yell at you Stevie. Please don't cry." Bucky pulled his loose tie off as he spoke. With a look of intense concentration Bucky used the soft fabric to dry Steve's face. Steve leaned into the touch.

Bucky made one last pass with the tie over Steve's face. He lingered a few seconds on the scratch marks on Steve's cheeks, the ones Bucky gave him in the final battle, before pulling away. Steve let out a whine that had Bucky chuckling back.

"Well, I did my best but can't expect miracles with that ugly mug of yours," Bucky commented as he tossed the soiled tie over the side of the railing. He gave Steve a smirk that was daring Steve to say something about the tie. Steve rolled his eyes "I thought you said I was your love?" Steve asked.

Bucky shrugged before saying, "Just because you're important to me has nothing to do with your looks. Besides it was mid battle talk. Can't trust half of what was said, it was probably untrue."

Steve took in the pink of Bucky's cheeks and how Bucky's eyes kept shifting everywhere but to Steve's. Taking a breath Steve decided to go for it. "What if I want what you said and more to be true?" Steve asked hesitantly.

Bucky straightened up, shock and hope written all over his face, his ears and tail puffing out. "You would?" Bucky said softly back. Steve reached out, twining his hands within Bucky's. "I would very much like whatever you want to give me for however long you would like to," Steve declared. Bucky stared, his face stoney before he smiled. "Then I hope that you're ready to deal with me until the end of time. Because I am not going anywhere." As he spoke Bucky brought his hands up cupping Steve's face.

Once more Steve leaned into the touch. "Then it is a good thing that I don't plan on going anywhere without you," Steve whispered the words against Bucky's lips before moving the rest of the way to make contact.

At this moment, on the edge of something new, Steve was not afraid to fall. He knew that Bucky would catch him.

From now till the end of the line.

The End



Author's cut

Chapter by Aquatigermice

Chapter Notes

> So. I sent my story to my beta thinking it was ready. But it was not. My beta advised me that I needed to shift the focus away from some of the other characters and back to Steve. I really liked these parts so instead of throwing them completely out I am putting them here for your enjoyment. I hope you like them. :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 5: Contact

Steve rolled on to his back in his sleeping bag. He wasn't quite awake yet. Just coming out of a deep sleep though he was unsure why. He always slept better nowadays on the floor. Beds were just too soft. Steve wasn't sure if it was something that Hydra had done or the misplaced power that was racing through him.

Whatever it was, Steve was much more antsy than he had been in the past. Exercise would help a little. Not much since his body wasn't that strong yet. While he couldn't get his body to transform into Captain Rogers, the 6 foot 2 golden hair 260 pounds of muscle, the power blast did heal all his old ailments. Steve missed the other body but he was used to this one.

Which was helpful in a way. Steve was now forced to look at problems a different way. It had been "I could use the Captain to punch my way out of any situation." And if he did get jammed up, then Bucky would gun them down an escape path. Now Steve had to think more. Not that this was a bad thing since it helped him understand his fellow teammates more. His connection to Clint

had grown since Clint's only power was being able to shoot arrows with a deadly accuracy.

That and be a damn good spy.

Clint would have been here now but he was still recovering from the Winter Soldier first appearance and attack. Steve refused to call him Bucky. He couldn't think of his friend, brother, his well... his everything like that. No this was just a creation that Hydra had made. They would get Bucky back no matter what. Though everyone warned Steve that they weren't sure what Bucky would be like mentally when he came home.

Steve figured they would deal with that part later. Anything had to be better than what Hydra was using him for now. Plus Steve and the others would be there to deal with the emotional fallout. His friends were already helping Steve heal.

The fact that Tony was here right now was lifting Steve's soul. Tony had told Steve sometime after his return, "It wasn't you, Steve. I know that now. I won't lie that there were times when I did blame you for it all but our friends, our team was there for me and are still there for me. I may have lost my blood family but I still have this family. The one that was founded by you. While you were gone, we got stronger. I believe the reason was so that we could be here for you now. So whatever you need, I am here for it. Even if that includes going after your brainwashed robo boyfriend."

That confession meant so much to Steve than he could ever say. Steve hoped that he could repay Tony in the future for such faith.

A loud snore had Steve looking over to where Thor was sprawled out on top of his sleeping bag. Even though Thor was still injured, he had come along. "I must see if I can persuade Loki to return. He is my brother." The team didn't argue. They all had their own ideas as to if Loki would ever come back and if he should be forgiven. They also had their theory as to what exactly was the nature of Loki and Thor's relationship. To Steve it was eerily close

to what he and Bucky had. That and the look that Thor had in his eyes every time he talked of Loki was very familiar to Steve.

Looking to his left, Steve stared at where Sam was sitting in a tree above them keeping watch. It was just the four of them. They had left Asgard in the hands of King Odin and a few other non-avengers who were capable of fighting Hydra.

Steve and the others were on their way to an outskirt town. One of Tony's projects had been to get a satellite into space (when Peggy moved the planet; all the satellites were destroyed in the shift.) Getting one out there would mean global communication. Something the Avengers were in need of.

The satellite hadn't even been up in the air for more than a few hours before they were alerted to a distress call from a ship that had crashed landed on the planet. From what they were able to get from the looping message, the ship was full of fighters.

When they asked Tony what he thought about how quickly Midgard had been found, Tony had said, "Are you asking me about my theories? Ok, well, let's get weird. If my calculations are right – and they normally are – not only have we been pulled into a pocket dimension, but also our time lines are a little messed up. Meaning for us, we have only been gone for seventy years. But out here it was more than that. My guess is that it's been at least a hundred years. Probably more. A good amount of time has passed and our little planet has been forgotten. So this ship was probably on its way to wherever and didn't expect a planet to suddenly be here."

Steve ran it by Peggy who said that the theory had sounded strong. She couldn't prove any of it since all frequencies of the SSR were not replying back to her. Which also worried Steve. He hoped that by finding these people and hopefully before Hydra did that they would be able to get some real information on what was going on here.

Letting out a breath, Steve rolled to the side. Dawn was still a few hours away. And when it was time to get up, they would have a lot of walking ahead of them. So it was best to get what sleep that Steve could while he had the chance. Steve let his eyes drift shut only to jerk them back open.

Steve swore he saw a flash of metal.

Straining his ears, Steve listened beyond the noise of the camp. There was the hiss of the fire, a hoot of a far off owl and then Steve heard it. The sound of a twig being snapped.

He would have ignored it, passing it off as sounds of the fire if Steve didn't know that the fire was nothing but coals. Steve closed his eyes listening as another snap rang through the air. Whoever it was was moving around the camp. And they were headed for Tony!!

Steve was up then. Scrabbling out of his sleeping bag. He could hear Sam calling his name but Steve didn't have time to reply because the Winter Soldier was stepping out of the shadows right beside Tony's bag, knife in hand.

Praying to his ancestors, to the past Captains, Steve hoped that they would give him the strength to save Tony. Steve held out his hand as the Winter Soldier raised his knife.

In one blink it was empty. Next there was a glow. Then a loud clunk as the Soldier's blade was held at bay by a glowing sword. A sword that was an exact replica of the Sword of Erskine. Only it was stronger in a way. Steve felt more connected to this phantom blade than he had ever been to the cold metal and steel.

Steve took just a moment to feel the joy that was singing through his body at seeing the Sword again and the slight disappointment that his body hadn't changed too. That he was still small. Then Steve straightened his stance and pushed upwards, driving the Soldier away from a now awake and shocked Tony. "Buck!" he

hissed out. But the Soldier didn't look at Steve, he was looking behind him. Steve could hear Sam and Thor moving.

The Soldier must have heard him too. Bucky's ears lifted just for a second before flattening back against his head. The Soldier took one more look at Steve, then at the sword with icy cold eyes before he turned, running in the woods.

Steve didn't even think. "Bucky!!" he called, running after him. Steve couldn't lose him again. Not when he was so close. The vines and tree roots fought his every move but Steve used his newly summoned blade to cut his way through.

The woods gave way to a small clearing. Steve was just entering it when Bucky was almost to the edge. Without much thought, Steve felt the sword shift in his hands. A moment later it was a circular shield. Doing a quick calculation Steve spun in the air, sending the shield flying.

He aimed it so that it would hit Bucky in the back of the head. It should have been enough force to knock Bucky out. Maybe even recalibrate him. Instead, Bucky stopped running, reaching out and grabbing the shield in midair with his metal arm.

Steve stared impressively at the sight. Then he had to scramble as the shield was being thrown back at him with such a force that it made Steve slide in the dirt. When he looked up Bucky was gone.

…

It had been a long depressing hike to the small town closest to the crash site. One that was surprisingly lacking anymore Winter Soldier sightings, as well as Loki.

The good news was that they did find the survivors. A group of fighters called the Guardians of the Galaxy. A motley group that included a tree, a raccoon, a deadpan fighter, an empath, a space pirate with a passion for setting his own ship on fire and two siblings. Gamora and Nebula. Daughters of Thanos. Who were now on the side of Shield.

Chapter 7: The Other Captain

Finding the Guardians had turned out to be very informative to the Avengers.

"Thanos is moving his whole fleet in this direction," Nebula had told them. "We didn't know why at first. We thought it was because they finally found our headquarters. Then we crashed here."

Steve had known a little about Thanos. Not a lot. Peggy was always reluctant to tell Steve and Bucky about Thanos. Steve didn't know why other than figuring that it would strike a wave of fear that could drain them all. There was already so much in front of them. And it seemed to keep growing.

"We need to strike now. We could call for backup. They can be here shortly. Besides, there are some people that you should probably meet," Gamora had told the team.

There was a short argument over whether or not those coming to help could make it in time. But that fear was quickly shut down. "When the sisters asked for our help in leaving, we took all of Thanos' Hyper Drive systems from his whole fleet. A task that was surprisingly easy to complete. So he is going to be taking the slow route to get to us," Rocket the racoon had said.

Contacting the Homebase of Shield was made easier with all the newer technology that was aboard the crashed ship. Steve had never seen Tony so excited about technology before. The hardest part was getting the ship back to Asgard.

Hydra had gotten wind that something was up, sending not only Loki and the Winter Soldier for repeat attacks, but also the Twins and units of soldiers all along the route they were using. Steve was both looking forward to the attacks. It meant another chance to see Bucky. Those ears, that tail. Steve was even starting to

grow fond of the metal arm too. It meant that Bucky was here. And another chance to try and get him to remember Steve.

The Guardians proved more than capable of holding off repeat attacks.

Mantis was in fact able to pick up on the HYDRA forces ahead of time. "There are a lot of mixed emotions coming from the soldiers. The Frost one has many conflicting feelings. With the metal-armed one, you can tell there is a real bond between you, Captain and him. Even when he is trying to kill you, he has strong positive emotions for you." Steve wasn't sure what to make from that statement.

After the ship was moved to Asgard; Rocket, Steve and Tony had a brain session on how to make contact with SHIELD. Which was how they got in touch with Nicholas J Fury, the leader of the Resistance that had been taking place in the rest of outer space. He sent them Captain Marvel or Carol Danvers who was like Steve, a member of the SSR.

Her body was like that of Captain Rogers. Tall, blonde and full of strength. Thor had been so enamored that Carol had to tell him that "I have a wife and we have a girlfriend. So I have to tell you to back off, cutie," she had said firmly. A lot of times Thor was overly friendly when he was excited. It often came across as Thor being interested. Though he did have a very open bedroom door policy. At least that is what Bruce had told him.

In this case, Thor was just interested in other worlds and politics. Talking with Thor had held Carol up for a few minutes after the meeting. But when she was done she sought Steve out. "I wanted to meet you. I could tell right away that you are the one who has it," she said, while taking his hand. Her own power called to his, bringing out the green glow of the Captain.

Steve had watched as her own power flowed out the exact same color. "When Captain Carter left the SSR there was a gap. Many saw the Captain as a beacon of hope," Carol said softly. "The SSR

had been taking power from the Stones for longer than most planets have been colonized. Using it as an energy source. It was decided that something drastic needed to be done since Thanos was hunting our people down with ease without our protector the Captain around.

“Children were all gathered. And one by one they were thrown in the energy vat. I was the last and the only one to survive. The power had been absorbed into my body giving me some of the powers that the original Captains had. And a few other tricks. While I was in the vat Thanos attacked us. By the time I crawled out of the vat, our people were dead and I was alone until Fury found me," Carol finished.

Frowning Steve asked "Other powers. Like what?" He was still holding her hands. It felt like some kind of recharging circuit. The longer that he held on the better he felt. It reminded him of Steve when he was little and used to have nightmares. Bucky used to hold his hand and Steve would feel ten times better. Carol smiled, before lifting into the air and taking Steve with her. "Flying for one," she said with a chuckle. They only hovered for a few before they came back down. "What is your weapon?" Steve asked excitedly. He never met someone like him before beside Buck. And there was still so much he didn't know about the Captain's powers.

"I don't have one. But that Stark guy said that you are in a similar situation. Since I know a thing or two about having such a wild thing inside you. I can give you some pointers before we raid that base." Carol offered. It seemed too good to be true but it was also too good to pass up.

There was just one thing that bothered him. "Shouldn't you be, I don't know, gathering forces to fight elsewhere. Or bringing more troops here to fight Thanos?" Steve asked. Normally he wasn't one to question such things but he needed to know.

Carol just smiled. "You and your friend are the last of our kind. That means your family. Your friend more than you. His sister

Rebecca Barnes Proctor was my Grandmother. She always talked about her brother who was so kind to her before he was sent away. My Grandmother had fought in her own way in honor of her brother. So I am gladly doing this for him."

Chapter 10 : Come Home

The ice cracked from the energy that the out of place portal was giving off.

It wasn't the first portal to show up here. There had been one that appeared a few weeks before. Only that one had been less powerful. The person that had come through the first portal didn't go very far. Just a few steps before collapsing into the deep snow drifts.

They had stayed there for hours before finally rising. Using summoning spells for small things such as dry wood and a small tent. The fire took some time to build. The snow and lands of Jotunheim had a magic of their own which came from The Casket of Ancient Winters. A gem that had been around almost as long as the Infinity Stones had.

The people of Jotunheim had run a long time ago across the galaxies before finally settling on Midgard. Though they chose to stick to the northernmost parts of the planet, they were an isolated people but they did keep up regular trade between the other inhabitants of the planet. The Casket was a very powerful gem that kept the lands protected from such things as fire.

But Loki was persistent until he was finally able to work around the gem's magic. A fire that floated above the snow. The same fire that Thor faced as he stepped out of the portal's warm circle and into the deathly cold.

He straightened, the charm around his neck keeping him warm, before he took in his brother. Loki was a mixture of pale white and dark blue. He was more blue than white, a sign that Zola's magic was fading.

There were some strips of some kind of meat that Loki had on sticks rotating over the fire. It smelled good.

"Are you here to arrest me?" Loki's voice came out rough and scratchy. "No," Thor replied. "I am here to talk." Loki scoffed but waved his hand to the other side of the fire, making a log appear. Thor moved to it, sitting down with a grunt slumping onto the log. "You look tired, brother. I have to say it's not a good look for you." The comment was sharp but Loki's voice was soft. Thor could hear the undertones of affection. It made him happy. While he was with Hydra, Loki was nothing but bitter.

Thor was tired of that. Tired of the abuse, of the pain and the fear that Loki could be killed by their enemy or worse one of his friends at any time and that it would be all Thor's fault. And was even more tired now that he was using his Stone's power. "I am tired, Loki, so very tired," Thor complained. Saying it aloud made him want to curl up in the snow and sleep.

A moment later a cup was floating beside his head. Thor had to blink a few times before he realized that it wasn't an illusion. By the smell it was one of Loki's potions. The pick-me-up one that Loki used to make constantly for Thor back when they were home. Thor drank it in one go. Feeling the magic ease into him.

Thor watched as the cup refilled. His eyes watering with tears. He had so much to say but he just couldn't form the words right now.

Meanwhile to fill the silence, Loki passed him two of the meat skewers. But by the time they had finished eating, a few tears had flowed down his face. Thor snuffled a little. His plan was not going at all how he had hoped. He wanted to come here and get Loki's help. But now he wanted to know why Loki did what he did and why he ran after helping them save Clint.

"Here, take this," Loki said. Thor hadn't even seen Loki move. Loki now stood beside Thor, in hand was a piece of cloth. "You were always such an ugly crier," Loki said, dabbing at Thor's face before placing the cloth in his hands. "Not sure how the Jane woman puts up with you," Loki spit out as he moved back to his log.

Thor sat up a little. "Jane?" Thor's mind started to try and connect dots. Loki was never one to say things if it didn't have some sort of meaning. "Is she the reason why you left?" Thor watched Loki look away. "I know you didn't see eye to eye with her but I don't see how that was a reason to run away like you did." At Thor's words, Loki turned sharply back. "You don't know half of the things that were going on in your happy go lucky world, you stupid oaf!!" Loki shouted.

Frowning Thor sat up glaring. He may have let a lot of things slide off him but that didnt make him stupid. "You are delusional, Loki. Making up things so that you could be dramatic," Thor shouted out. Angry that the conversation had gone to yelling so fast. Loki glared as he said cooley back, "Why are you here?"

Why was he here?

WHY THE HELL WAS HE HERE??!!

What kind of question was that? He was here for his brother. Here to bring him home. But that was not what he said. Instead he said, "I came because we need you. Thanos is coming and we need all the help we can get. Your magic is the best in the land. I don't think we can win without you." Thor forced each word out. It was the same that the others had said at the meeting.

Though after the meeting, the Avengers had talked it over. Loki knew all their styles and had the magic to heal. It was something they would need. They all knew how Loki was and they desperately wanted to forgive their childhood friend. And Thor knew that deep down Loki wanted to redeem himself.

"And if I refuse, what happens then? Will those same armies you have been gathering come for me instead?" Loki asked. Thor shook his head. "No one will force you Loki. We are not Hydra. Father has already talked to King Laufey. They agreed that this land will be yours if you wish to stay. But the whole planet is going to be at war soon. Even the Jotuns are gearing up to fight." Thor knew that he had hit a nerve as Loki's eyes went wide.

"You will fight too?" Loki said as if he just realized that this was what would happen. "I have to," Thor said. Loki frowned. "You don't. You could stay here with me. Just throw the stupid Stone back through the portal," Loki offered.

"I can't," Thor said before adding, "I don't want to leave you behind. I would rather you be at my side." Loki frowned, standing up now. "Why can't you just stay? We can have everything we ever wanted. I can give you anything you want. Is it because of Jane? Would you rather have her? Or maybe Sif?" Loki shifted forms between the two ladies.

Thor frowned, going to Loki's side. He carefully took Loki's hands. "I don't know why you're so focused on Jane. I know that I slept with them both. But after you left, they met each other. Fell in love with one another. They are married. Is that what is keeping you away?" Thor asked.

When Loki was once more quiet, Thor pressed forward. "If that was it, you can come home. We can fight side by side again. Be brothers once more," Thor started but Loki interrupted him. "As much as I wish for things to be that simple again there is no going back for us. I can't be like that anymore."

It was now starting to click inside Thor's head. The way that Loki always followed Thor's every move. All the pranks and non-fatal accidents that happened to Thor's former lovers. Thor had always brushed it off as Loki being younger and wanting more attention. But thinking about it now Loki was only a month or two younger than Thor was.

Relief flooded Thor. Because he had a secret too. He was about to tell Loki when Loki blurted out. "I killed Tony's parents." Which Thor thought that was an odd thing to confess to since everyone knew that James and Steve had led the attack.

"What I mean is, Hydra had no plans to attack the land of Technology. I told them that for me bring them both the super-soldiers alive, my payment was getting rid of Howard Stark. I didn't mean for Maria to be killed too. My hope was that she and the people would flee after the King was killed. I just got lucky that Steve and James were still in the early stages of brainwashing and didn't kill Tony," Loki admitted. He looked at Thor shyly as if waiting to be screamed at.

But the screaming never came. Thor had learned early on that screaming at Loki never got the truth. It just made him more defensive.

"Why did you do it?" Thor asked. He thought Loki wouldn't answer him but Loki shuddered a little before he opened his mouth. "Howard Stark was not a nice man. He would smile at everyone. Was generous and kind on the surface but beneath that he was evil."

Loki took a breath before continuing. "Tony had come to me after young Peter had died. Said that he didn't believe the statement that Peter had tried to take the Downingtown Stone and the power had killed him. Tony was right in his suspicions. Howard had not only killed Peter but Rhodey and a few others too. Anyone that Howard saw was beginning to have sway on Tony, Howard deemed them an enemy to the kingdom."

Thor could barely believe it. He remembered Rhodey who had died in a tragic accident while trying out new tech for the royal army. And of course Peter. Tony couldn't stop gushing about the young genius that he hoped to have as Head Engineer when Tony became King. The only person who came close to liking the boy as much as Stark was Loki.

Both Loki and Tony had been so devastated when Peter did what he did. Everyone had chalked it up to Peter trying to be a hero. It was all he ever wanted to be. The boy had always been impatient for his turn to fight. Reckless in training.

Tony missed a lot of team practices and meetings after the kid had died. Then a few months later his kingdom was destroyed. Thor had never thought that it all had been connected.

But there had to be something else. Thor knew Loki. He was motivated by self interest for the most part. And while he liked the kid there were still others that Loki cared for more, like their Mother and Thor himself.

"You found something else out didn't you before you went to Hydra to make your deal?" Thor said slowly. "Yes," Loki said. "While under the spell, Howard confessed to having leaked Odin's army's whereabouts leading to his capture. I didn't know at the time that Odin had escaped. But Howard was making plans to kill you and Mother. He had already started work on a cyborg that he was using Peter's body for. Was going to run blood from you through it in order for him to be able to use the Stone of Asgard. He hoped that if that worked he could do the same to all the Stone holders."

Thor was stunned. Sure he had suspicions at times about some things that had happened but this was beyond that. He never could have connected all this in this way.

"So you went to Hydra and hoped that they would take Howard out?" Thor said in awe. "I did. I even sealed Howard's lab so no one could repeat his experiments. I knew the Avengers wouldn't be able to handle what was happening. And Hydra had been so inviting. I just saw it all and remember at the beginning thinking that Hydra was about loyalty and teamwork. That it was a family but really it is all about personal gain. It wasn't what I wanted and by the time I realized that I was trapped." Tears were flowing down Loki's face.

And Thor couldn't take it any longer as he pulled Loki into a hug.

"We used to be so close. You and I. And we just grew apart. You towards magic and me in my combat training. I used to notice that you made more of an effort to be around me after I slept with someone. I think deep down I knew you were jealous. I also knew that nothing made me happier than you at my side," Thor confessed. It made Loki look up sharply.

"Yes, we need you and your magic in the coming battle. But I need you at my side because I know that you will have my back completely and I yours. Just like you have my heart. So Loki," Thor said, pulling away. "Follow me back. Lead the team to the lab so we can show them and destroy it for good. Be at your rightful place at my side.

Thor held out a hand to Loki. "Come home with me?"

Chapter End Notes

Carol is not only Bucky's grandniece but she is married to Maria Rambeau and their girlfriend is Valkyrie.

End Notes

Ok let's talk about notes. When I saw this story I wanted it right off the bat because Bucky had a tail and cat ears. I knew a little about SheRa from when I was a kid but not much. I had a lot of thoughts before going into this. Most of which didn't make it into the story. I actually wrote the ending first because there was a cool prom scene in SheRa that I wanted to include because Catra was rocking that suit.

While watching the show I wrote 8 pages of lines that I really liked. Most of those have been sprinkled throughout the story. Sadly even with that this story was fighting me. It took a few awesome ideas such as Peggy being an AI for this story to come together. That and this web series called RWBY and a slight touch of Avatar the Last AirBender.

I didn't have enough time to really dive into the other characters. SheRa has a lot of awesome and complex characters. I think one of my biggest problems was Catra. She is a very messed up person. Some of it was her own fault, others not so much. Her character reminds me a lot of Loki which was why I split her into two so that we could get some of that craziness that she had in the show in this story.

One of my biggest problems was who to give each stone to. I played around with the thought of who got what for a while and finally settled on this arrangement.

Other interesting information:
Longmans is the name of the publisher of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde. Rush for Russia of course. Waverly is where Clint is said to have been born. And Downingtown well you should know who that is.

A.I. Peggy is actually Peggy's soul. Howard did have the Soul Stone after all. The power of the Stone in this story causes

the User to bring souls back. This is not the same as bringing back a person from the dead.

The fight between Clint and Nat was between Barney. Or at least what was left of him

I hope you enjoyed it. And thanks for reading.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!